
THE
MIRAGE
IN
THE
MIST
SWAYAM SHAKYA

THE MIRAGE IN THE MIST

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THE MIRAGE IN THE MIST
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PROLOGUE

In an enigmatic location where shadows dance on the brink of vision, fluorescent lights flicker like secrets, and mist wraps its mirage around hidden intricacies, a young man named Jason deems himself piqued in an unparalleled and miserable place hidden from his surroundings.

Timeless and undefined, the novel conveys an idea of vintage locations that are primitive in comparison to today's contemporary environment, and also holds an old-historic panorama of fictitious and monochrome world. The narrative implies that the era exists only in black and white to reflect the thrilling perspective of the author.

Jason, a young man in his **20**s with blue eyes and brown hair, weighing **70** kg and **175** cm tall, residing in the downtown area, finds himself entangled in a web of bizarre things occurring around him. While the pressure in his mind devours his entire being, he encounters **Maze**, a young lady of Jason's age with green eyes and blonde hair, weighing around **45** kg and **162** cm tall, working as an assistant for Dr. **Dave Dowski**, a retired surgeon and psychiatrist of the early **60**s, weighing **65** kg and **167** cm tall, who runs a clinic in the heart of downtown, and others.

The clock ticking in this mysterious and evocative tale never stops, drawing our protagonist closer to his haunted past and ultimately changing his life forever. The mystery takes shape as the stage is set, the players are assembled, and a web of suspense, drama, madness, and unexpected turns are woven together.

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For the ones who love to read, imagine and explore.

PART-1

CHAPTER I

THE SYMPHONY OF ASSIMILATION

One rainy morning, a young man, completely soaked in the rain, appeared from the bushy passage, which led him to the entrance. It was subtle to him; the huge walls of the shrine, the atmosphere around him, and the wind of aberration astonished him. The man gently lowered his back, bowed before the entrance, racked his boots beside the gate, slowly turned back with his tensed blue eyes to confront the air of affliction towards the gate. The indecisive thoughts were starting to crumble his mind. Then, he started questioning himself emotionally. A storm inside his head started to fluctuate his stability. One could have absurd feelings, connecting towards such an irksome situation. Eventually, he entered inside the *gumba*.

The historical sculpture and ceilings, the spacious and marvelous hallway, the collection of *Thangka* paintings of *Sikkimese* and *Tibetan* Buddhist society, and the vibrant picture constituting the head of the council along with other members, flattered his vision. He could only gaze at them. Suddenly, an old, tall man approached him.

"Have a seat, young man. The council of the monks has arrived. Please maintain discipline and welcome them, will you?" The old man requested.

"Okay." The young man nodded.

"Here comes the council. Please stand up."

Everybody attending the session stood to welcome the council of monks.

"*Saadhu! Saadhu! Saadhu!*" They started to chant.

"*Sawdhu?*" The young man tried to imitate inside his head.

"*Saadhu! Saadhu! Saadhu!* Greetings everyone. Please take your seats." The head monk permitted.

"We've gathered on the occasion of commemorating 20 years of the inauguration of this shrine. It has been a pleasure for me and the council to perform our duties and deliver our teachings and knowledge for over two decades. We're really thankful for everyone's support. *Saadhu! Saadhu! Saadhu!*"

"*Saadhu! Saadhu! Saadhu!*" Everybody in the crowd except the young man chanted.

"So, on this special occasion, we're here to answer any of your doubts and questions, regardless of the topic. Feel free to ask questions with proper discipline and without any hesitation," announced the head monk.

Thus, the people in the crowd began to clear up their doubts, and ask questions related to their lives and interest.

"How can I make more money? I am not satisfied with my current earning. Also, my life is boring. Please help me," asked a woman to the head monk.

"Firstly, this is the most common question we have ever heard," smiled the head.

"Where do you live, young lady? Is it the valley or the downtown?" asked the head.

"In the downtown, since I was born," replied the woman.

"How much do you earn monthly?" asked the head.

"Roughly **50,000** in a year. I am a junior nurse by profession." She replied.

"That's fairly sound income. We could enjoy our meal thrice a day for years with such amount.", the head replied back with the crowd enjoying his humor.

"Are you married?" asked the head.

"Well, I am divorced," answered the woman.

"That's all I have to ask. I have an advice which might help you." The head concluded his questioning.

"Please tell me, sir." She replied in an excited manner.

"*First*, you need to move to the valley. For the time being, life in the valley is superior to life in the downtown. *Second*, the valley is in need of qualified staff and nurses due to widespread infection in the locality, and they're willing to pay the amount equivalent to the rate at the city to qualified applicants. As you seem to be experienced and dedicated towards your profession, you will certainly qualify for the post, which will take care of your income. *Finally*, develop a relationship that suits you the best. You are a young, beautiful, and ambitious woman. If you're divorced at such a young age, that means things didn't go well between you and your ex-husband. Eventually, both of you decided to break the relationship, along with the bond, promises, trust, and such. But trust me, you can always try a second time. Relationships are difficult to maintain, but that is also why they are extremely mesmerizing. They are like a cup of Tibetan tea; for instance, it would only taste better if you properly boiled the water, mashed the leaves, mixed the spices properly, and served it in a clay cup.

And believe me, if you are honest to your deeds, it would result in an everlasting sequence of joy in your life. I can assure you that you will find someone who would fill the empty space of a partner in your life, whether it'd be a man, a woman, kids, pets, and such. All you need is to try harder and smarter, have faith on your progress, and work on yourself to convert it to a fairy tale of your desires."

"Sounds nice to me. But is it worth it to go through all of this? Isn't there an easy way?" replied the woman.

"Well, it's your choice whether to take it or neglect it. This is your life, and you should decide it. I am just trying to show you a better path for your desires. Whether you make it or not, that is up to you. Although I wouldn't prefer shortcuts either, I warn you that an easier way can help you succeed sometimes, but the true essence of the original way enables your life to reach the heights of the sky, filled with countless possibilities," answered the head.

"Thank you, sir," exclaimed the woman, expressing her genuine satisfaction with his opinions.

"Now, it's my turn. Greetings, sir. I have three sons, and all of them are above **25** years of age. I love them equally, and I am a retired man now. I am a third generation businessman from our family. And my sons are engaged elsewhere in their profession. I want to distribute the property to my sons. Should I divide the property equally for three of them or should I seek an alternative? Please help me, sir," asked a retired man from the crowd.

"Hmmm.... sure. Could you tell me about your sons in detail? I mean their ages, relationships with you, and such," asked the head.

"*First*, my eldest son is **29** years old. He is the most mature, understanding, and caring among them. He is already married and has two children. He lives in the valley and works as an reporter.

Secondly, my second son is **27** years old. He is the most intelligent and hard-working among them. He lives in the valley with his wife and is blessed with a daughter. He's a neurologist for a hospital located in the downtown. Also, he earns the most among them.

Finally, my youngest son is **25** years old. He's the most loved and carefree among them. He is a advisor for an **INGO**. He spends most of his time with us and helps us with our daily activities and normal household chores. He is unmarried and doesn't intend to marry for now.

That's all," described the retired man.

"Well, there's a simple solution to this."

"Well, your sons are pretty stable in their lives. And given the descriptions, I assume that they will respect your decision and won't argue about anything else. So, your decision would be the key here," answered the head .

"Is it this simple? I thought it would be more complex than this," questioned the retired man.

"Why do we need to make simple things complicated without any reason and necessity? Firstly, think wisely about a simple solution. If you think it won't work, keep trying with a different approach. But I must warn you not to muddle things just because you do not idealize the simple way. Your only focus should be the solution of your problem, not the judgement of methods. The hardest path isn't always the wisest path," replied the head.

"Wouldn't it be better if I equally divided my property among them?" questioned the retired man.

"Well, it seems fine too. However, your decisions should be equity-based rather than equality-based. The purpose of equity means equality of outcome, not equality of opportunity, and it fits the scenario perfectly. It might not feel right for a while, but have faith in your decision."

"Thank you, sir. I will decide properly," replied the retired man in a convinced manner.

"I don't think this head monk is making any sense. People are blindly agreeing with his opinions. He is just inspiring the audience to be too optimistic. The real world is a mess. This is bullshit," uttered the young man inside his head in a frustrated manner.

A few other topics, like the cause and end of suffering, the path of enlightenment, the attainment of Nirvana, and the fold paths of Buddha, were factual but not the most original thoughts. Out of all these topics, there was one that stood out. Everyone went numb and silent when they heard a new voice from the crowd.

"Does the **body** control the **soul**? Or is it the **opposite**? Or is it **something** our **mind** tricks us to **believe** in?" asked the young man to the head monk with a smirk on his face.

Everyone in the crowd started to stare the young man to praise his unique concept.

The head monk stared at the young man for a while.

"Well, I see hesitation in your eyes. What is troubling you, young man? " questioned the head monk.

The young man stood silently for a while, then he looked down and sat there, with eyes of confusion.

"Well, thank you for joining us today. Until next time, farewell everyone." The head monk concluded the event.

"Not you, young man." The head monk approached towards the young man.

After everyone left the place, the monk separated from the council to meet the young man.

"Who're you, and have we ever met?" The monk inquired of the man.

"I'm **Jason**. This is my first time here," replied the young man.

"Strangely, I feel a mysterious haze inside you. Anyway, to answer your question, I must understand the depth and purpose of it. Would you mind telling me?"

"Why does that even matter? Didn't you say that we're free to ask anything, regardless of any context. If you are not answering me, I guess I will leave."

The monk smiled and answered his question anyway.

"Calm down. Save your energy for later, young man. In response to your question, I ask, "What if there is no authority of control?" Now, answer me."

"What do you mean?" asked the young man with a visibly confused aura.

"Why is it that we always want to think about the superiority of two things? Why don't we analyze the concept of **equilibrium**? For instance, it is possible to believe that one has authority over the other. However, if that's the case, how would you explain the simultaneous existence and systematic purpose of both? If either one of them is absent, doesn't it affect our lives directly? Have you ever seen a man with a soul but no body, or the opposite?"

"Well, it isn't possible to have none of them either, because it would neglect the principle of **existence**. What I am trying to convey is that the body and the soul have equally valuable duties. They are their **counterparts**. You should not try to visualize them as two completely different objects. Even if you see it as a **coincidence**, there is always a valid **reason** to justify it."

"And to answer the **concept** of **mind**, your mind wants you to believe that someone has **authority** over the **two**. It is obvious to have such **doubts**, but be wise enough to question your **beliefs**. The human mind is a grassland of thoughts and ideas. You tend to believe what you think is right. But, my friend, you're not the judge to decide what is right and what isn't. And that's what makes it justifiable. There's no such thing as **right** or **wrong** in this world. Every deed we do has a sole purpose, and the creator is the only judge of this debate. We humans are meant to play our roles to either believe in being **righteous** or **sinful**."

"Everything in this universe happens for a reason, even if we are not wise enough to see it. In time, every mysteries are solved. You just have to wait patiently," concluded the head monk.

"Your world is too optimistic, like a fairy tale, old man," replied Jason.

"I would say that it is **optimal**. Not everything I'll say is always correct. My life is an enormous vessel of countless experiences; my character is the outcome of my journey; and my words are just opinions that tend to convince the seekers." The monk drew to a close, while Jason seemed to clearly visualize those words.

"You should visit this place once in a while. It wouldn't hurt to share a cup of tea with this old man. We make the most authentic Tibetan tea in the country. You might like it," advised the monk to Jason.

"I'll think about it. If I still live to remember this, I'll visit you again someday." Jason departed from the shrine, followed by the dark clouds covering the platform, without being able to explain about his intention.

"Is the conversation over? It's about to rain. You should get inside the shrine, sir." The other monk from the council approached the head monk.

"Oh, why bother? We're done for today," replied the head.

"So, what do you think about him? Was he convinced?" asked the monk to the head.

"I am not really sure about it. I feel that he left the place without the answers he sought. But I have this strange feeling in my heart regarding this. Maybe I am worrying too much, or I wonder if it is because of my age," replied the head.

"Obviously, you are worrying too much. I bet you have grown a liking for him," uttered the monk.

"Yes, I have. I always knew this generation isn't all about weed and greed." The head left the scene with an elated smile on his face.

Meanwhile, battling with the wrath of the dark clouds, Jason survives an agitated journey to his apartment.

"Your shoes are terribly filthy. I had just finished cleaning the floors. Now, they're dirty again." A woman from the apartment yelled at Jason.

"Well, it's raining outside. What can the poor lad do?" Her husband interfered.

"Sorry for the trouble." Jason rushed towards his apartment.

The lunch that Jason bought was from her favorite restaurant as they were craving for it. The freshly made hamburgers with extra cheese and fries, a carbonara which was his second most favorite dish, and two strawberry milkshakes, were mouthwatering. He was excited to have a great time in his apartment, but also worried that the foods have gotten cold due to the traffic jam thanks to the heavy rain.

"I've bought your favorite dishes. Sorry to keep you waiting." Jason entered the apartment, waiting for the reply.

"Come on! It's not my fault. I was stuck in traffic due to this shitty rain. Forgive me already," shouted Jason while approaching towards her couch.

Afterward, what Jason discovered is **Sera's** wrist covered with blood. Soon after he questioned the situation, he encountered the dead eyes in front of him. The newly renovated floor and carpet had a horrific stain, that would haunt him for a long time. Seeing such an unexpected thing, Jason's chest started to feel heavy. He started to discover the void beneath him. Suddenly the emotions outburst which led to a loud mourn of agony. The composure of the room had the intense air of grief. The cold food accompanied the cold body of Sera, while Jason's joyful moment turned into a horror.

CHAPTER II

THE DROPLETS OF SHAMBLES

The aggressive monsoon finally began to cease. The windows could barely rest after the harsh battle with the group of droplets. While the weather started to calm down, the overwhelming pressure resided in Jason's apartment. He had been staring at the body like an inanimate object himself. The agonies inside his heart were nothing like he ever imagined. A strange sequence of musical instruments started to play inside his pre-occupied mind full of twists and turns, constructing an classical opera performance, and fully displaying the vivid memories of her aunt. While his head was loaded with a symphony of frustration, his phone rang all of a sudden, and his reaction was bloodcurdling. Suddenly, the doorbell rang at the same time. Jason was having a terrible time. He cautiously approached the door and unlocked it.

"Hey! Were you sleeping? Why didn't you answer?"

Jason kept staring at her.

"Are you okay? What happen? Talk to me, will you?" The **girl** with **green** eyes appeared and questioned him.

As soon as she started to question him about the situation, Jason went on his knees, but the girl immediately hugged her, and he started crying on her shoulders.

** *Several years ago* **

"Why does it rain?" muttered Jason, about **10** years old, as he stared out the window at the sky.

“Well, because it’s the time of the monsoon. During this season, we experience rainy days and nights.” Sera replied.

“....”

“Don’t you like when it rains?”

“No, I don’t.”

“Why so?”

“It makes me sad.”

“Why? What happened?”

“It irritates me when it rains. The droplets of rain, always striking together at the same spot, remind me of how lonely and confined my life is.”

Sera Willholm was a young and kind nurse who used to work at a **psychiatric ward** in the valley. Sera was in charge of the department for **orphaned** and **mentally retarded children**. That's where she met **Jason** for the first time.

During those years, the government experimented on children in order to prepare them for **war** and **combat**. The ward where she worked was the primary source of the wager. Those who cleared the experiment were sent to the authorized facilities to serve in the **military**, while those who didn’t clear the test remained in the ward. And Sera was in charge of taking care of those children who failed the experiment. One day, the government decided to halt the testing and stopped the entire processing. As a result, they decided on banishing the remaining children from the ward.

Sera vehemently opposed the decision and fought the government. She was completely disappointed with the government's news and tried her hardest to flee the area before it was destroyed by the blaze. However, she was powerless against an entire army. The brutal portrayal of an armed force had no mercy on them, yet somehow, she barely escaped with the remaining child, who was none other than Jason himself.

** *The next morning* **

"Shine and rise, my sunshine. Good morning," she chuckled while gently embracing, and kissing Jason on his cheeks while he faintly opened his eyes.

"Get up; it's **9:00** a.m. already. I am going to be late for work. Do you prefer cheese slices with bread or honey, baby?"

"I am sorry to tell you that we ran out of croissants and cereals, so please have these today. I swear, I'll buy them today on my way from work."

"Okay, Jason?"

"Jason?"

Jason was unable to hear for a while. His eyes were all red. He felt like his loaded head was getting crushed in a hydraulic press while his girl was talking. He was not fully awake, and his body was numb, and full of pain.

"Where am I? How did I get here?" asked Jason to her.

"In my apartment. Oh god, I guess you're still not awake. Who told you to drink all by yourself even though you can't handle it? Huh?" She scolded him.

"Was I drunk?" Jason inquired.

"Of course. Are you okay? Come on, let me help you. Grab my hand, and wear me tight like your jacket."

"Don't you like this side of me, babe?"

Jason stood confused for a while.

After a few minutes, she completed her breakfast and began to walk out of the door.

"Call me if you need something, okay? And please take a shower and don't go anywhere until I return. We're going to have a candlelight dinner today. Okay?" she asked Jason.

"Yeah. Okay," replied Jason.

"I love you. Take care. Bye."

"Come on, at least say something."

"Me too...." Jason waved back.

And so Jason was all by himself for the day.

He started to believe that he was actually drunk last night. Thus, he rested for a while, thinking that the effects of alcohol would eventually disappear. He frequently drank a few bottles of water, splashed some drops of can soda on his face, and tried similar things. After a while, he started feeling better. He thought that these methods had worked. It made him feel relieved for a while.

It had been about three to four hours since the girl left. He had nothing to do at all. Meanwhile, he saw a photograph on the desk. It was him and the girl, somewhere near the beach. Strangely, his eyes were full of tears, and he started to miss the girl. His heart suddenly started to beat abnormally, and he desired to see her as soon as possible. So, he decided to call her. All of a sudden, he realized that he didn't have his phone with him.

"Where did I keep it? I can't remember at all."

"I think she might know. I better call her. But, wait how the hell do I do that right now?" Jason started to portray his frustration in a silly manner.

"Come on, think Jason think. Where could it be?" Jason searched everywhere, but he was not able to find where his phone was.

"Oh wait, if I was at the party last night, maybe I dropped my phone there. But where was the party? I am not sure where I was yesterday."

"What is wrong with me? Why can't I remember?" Jason thought inside his head.

"If I can't remember anything, that means I was totally drunk. How did she manage to get me here?"

"She's so caring. She went through all of that for me. I love her so much. I wonder when she is coming home so that I can thank her for all the troubles she went through, just for me," Jason started imagining all of this stuff as per the given information by the girl.

His life had become a rollercoaster of various events that were totally unknown to him until today. Handling all these together turned out to be a headache for him. Once, he would get amazed at all the good, vibrant moments he had spent with her, and the other times were frustrating for him, regardless of any topic. It was a confusing time for Jason himself. During the entire afternoon, he had done nothing but overthink and complicate things. The cluster of bombshells was about to take over his gripping mind, but then he suddenly decided to clear his head with a cold and refreshing shower.

"Damn! The more I start thinking about everything, the harder it gets to remember everything. I need to relax now." Jason began to stop overthinking for a while.

While Jason was taking a shower with his eyes closed completely, a mysterious voice of a woman called his name with the sound of crows and vultures, vividly disturbing the background.

"Jason.... Jason...." The voice continued till Jason was fully aware of it.

At first, Jason thought he was mistaken and continued his shower. Meanwhile, he heard someone knocking on the door, and the same mysterious voice began to call him.

"What's going on?" Jason uttered inside his head while his toes went numb and his body was shivering with fear.

Afterward, he cautiously approached the door to see if someone was there. When he slowly began to unlock the door, he found out that he was locked inside the apartment. At the moment, Jason had thought of something bad that might happen to him or even be life-threatening. The confusion started to terrify him.

"What do I do? Why is the door locked? Where is the key? This sucks. Right now, I want to cry so hard, but the tears won't come out. This is the worst." Jason's frustration had controlled his emotions again.

"That's right. I could just get out of the window. That might work for me." Jason thought of a steady approach.

"Oh God! I thought I am at the first floor. Never mind."

And then he jumped out of the window. He was in a state of shambles, and he sought answers from the girl, who might have locked him unintentionally or might not.

For now, he searched for a telephone booth nearby to call her. Jason was walking for a few minutes. He had no idea where he was currently going, but he was constantly following the route towards the highway. While he was about to reach there, it began to rain all of a sudden, which forced Jason to stop on his path.

"Come on. I hate this time of the year. The weather is so unpredictable for us. I fucking hate the monsoon. Every moment of this season is frustrating."

"I wonder if she likes the rain. Have I ever asked her? Has she ever told me? I can't remember right now. This feels sick." Jason began to complain again.

Jason sat on the bench and started to patiently wait for the rain to cease. While he was waiting, he was observing multiple things. Each droplet hitting the exact spot like the previous one— the sound of frogs dancing in joy, the noise of birds and the people in the neighborhood, the dark clouds producing visible patterns of lightening, and such— started to distract him while he was waiting. Finally, the rain was over. He was relieved after waiting for hours, and he could finally keep going. However, the day was completely meant to be full of shockers for him.

Suddenly, he observed three men constantly staring at him. One of them was a tall blonde man wearing a single glove on his right fist; the other man was the fattest among them; and the last man had a scar on his face. All of them looked like thugs, thanks to their rowdy and flashy outfits. In response to their stare, Jason also did the same to get their attention and notice their reaction. They continued to stare at him, and Jason wasn't holding back either.

Both of the parties were sharing an intensive blows through their eyes, while the eyes of those men were portraying a grudge against Jason. In response, Jason's eyes had nothing but a pale glimpse of uncertainty. He lacked almost every sense, and his clueless expression busted a ravishing blow trying to counteract the mild situation. Finally, the group of men were irritated, and they began to move towards him furiously.

Jason sensed an immense danger, and rushed towards the girl's house immediately. And thus, another bombshell occurred on his already terrible day. At the end, he finally screamed and cried aloud.

"What the hell is wrong today? What did I do to deserve all this? For God's sake, when will this day end?" Jason muttered under his breath.

He had reached the sharp turn of the path, and her house was on the edge of it. Utilizing these crucial seconds, he jumped through the window in a stressed manner and banged it quickly. The heavy breathing was all he could do now. He slowly began to notice the place, which was not more than 100 square feet in area and had really sturdy furniture despite the old architecture. His clothes were completely filthy, and his shoes had messed up the white bedsheets. Now, he might have had to suffer her scolding too. His mind was totally disturbed, and all he needed was a genuine time to relax. Never had he ever thought of such a miserable day in his entire life.

"Knock...."

"Knock...."

"Knock...." Someone appeared in front of the house.

Jason's heart pumped rapidly, and his heartbeat was noticeably faster than usual. His entire body was fully doused with rain-water and sweat. The gravity of his frightened aura had raised the gravity of the room so immensely that it would dare to rupture not only the temperature scale, but also the cemented walls and ceilings. As the knocking on the door started to fade, his heart started to beat even more rapidly. He knew that if the door was open, he'd be a goner for sure.

The moment the door slowly started to unlock itself, Jason imagined the sequence of colors, visualizing the horror of being beaten by those men. Inside his head, those men have already begun to torture him. His mind forcefully created a distinct image where two of them had caught him through the shoulders, and the one with the glove on his right fist was punching him, and breaking his jaw while spilling out the blood all over his body and broken teeth beneath him. He was driven to a state where a slight overthinking might have risked his own life. He had no control over his body, and his eyes had already accepted the fate that his mind was showing him inside his head. However, a scattered ray of hope sparked inside his vision as it started to disclose the identity of the one behind the door. Hopefully, it was favoring his final testament to the remaining fortune.

"Babe! What happened to you? Who did this to you?"

"Hey, are you okay?"

Jason was numb and breathing heavily, while his body was aggressively shaking on the floor. His nose was covered with blood as a result of the imaginative pressure he felt.

She dragged him along slowly and let him settle onto the bed gradually. She started mopping the messy floor, managed all those misplaced items from the table, got his clothing off, and cleaned the untidy bed. And when his day eventually ended, Jason had already passed asleep. More than everything, he wanted that sleep. Surprisingly, he was the only one injured beside any other damage. He ignored the things that his brain had remembered so far and the things that affected the day's actual physical surroundings. Only Jason understood the horrible repercussions of dread and overanalyzing, rather than having a legitimate reason to observe such misery. Even as he was relaxing at the finish, there came another little mist of rain. The rainbow and sunset, followed by the harsh monsoon earlier, provided a warm welcome respite from his awful day.

CHAPTER III

THE ALBATROSS OF MISERY

It is no wonder that Jason has always hated monsoon since his childhood days. He always had a very clear image of how the ceiling fell over him due to heavy rain while he used to live with Sera. It continuously rained for weeks, and of all the other families in the vicinity, they were the only ones to feel the wrath of the dark clouds. In addition, they didn't get any kind of help from the locals, as those ignorants had no business with the deprived ones. Under the sky, the showers didn't have any mercy on them either. Neither they could afford to repair it nor have they had any other possible solution besides suffering inside that broken cottage. Though these events had very little to do with his current life, their relationship is still as identical as the relationship between the **hunter** and the **prey**, where Jason's fortune always ran out during the crucial moments. Given his character, he hadn't been very open-minded about anything throughout his life, so he would always complain about such matters and easily get frustrated over them. It wouldn't be immature of him to agree with it; he is still the boy he was yesterday.

With a blaring sound of thunder, Jason was awake, only to find himself on his girlfriend's lap.

"Good morning, my sunshine." The girl greeted him with kisses and warm cuddles.

"Yeah, good morning." He greeted back.

"Are you feeling well, babe?" She asked him in a slightly hesitant manner.

"I'm good. Yes, I am perfectly fine. Why'd you ask?" Jason replied.

"Nothing.... Never mind." She replied back.

Like the previous morning, Jason was clueless about what she was trying to say. Not even a little did Jason had any idea about what he was missing.

"Anyway, forget about it. Okay, tell me, what's the date today? Come on, tell me." She questioned him merrily.

Jason had no idea about the date. "Ahem, let me see the calendar. What's so special about it?" He answered her sarcastically. While he was being casual about the question, a sudden swing of mood appeared in his girl's face. Her dazzling face, full of expectations and surprises, suddenly turned into a furious and agitated expression. Eventually, he noticed the atmosphere and tried to clear his doubts and confusion.

"What's with that hilarious face? What happened? Did I do something wrong? Sorry for all the troubles, for the past and the future too." Jason attempted to cheer her.

"How could you forget today's date? You really don't care about me. I am leaving." She screamed at him.

"But this is your house. If I had done something wrong, I would be the one to leave. In fact, I am leaving. I am going to punish myself for hurting your feelings. I hope this will make you feel better." Jason mocked her to be more clear.

"No, wait. Don't try to act smart with me."

"I will kill you, you idiot."

"I have no idea what you're up to. So, could you please tell me what the occasion is today? Please?" Jason began to convince her and asked for forgiveness.

"You're the worst!" She exclaimed in an irritated manner.

"It's my birthday, you idiot. How could you forget it? This is one of the few days that you should never forget. I have never forgotten your birthday, so how could you? You're so mean."

"Oh yeah. I knew it." Jason had no idea about the date.

"I was just fooling you. How could I forget today's date?"

"Sorry for this act." Jason tried to convince her again, though he had no idea about her birthday; he had already started to overthink.

"Honestly?"

"Obviously. Happy birthday."

"Mhmm.... Hehe! Thank you so much."

Eventually, he fixed it properly, and he properly greeted her, holding her slender body from her waist and slowly pulling her towards him for a warm kiss in an old-school romantic way that she'd adore forever. Before long, they intensively started exchanging their emotions with each other without any concern for their surroundings. Jason had the physical control that had freed him to express his desires, and likewise, the girl wanted him to feel the heat inside her body. Struck by a necessary means to isolate the world and their current situation, the young and amorous bodies intimately engaged for the intercourse for hours like everything had come to an end, except their love.

** *A few hours later* **

"Do you have this weird feeling when everything feels like a **void** inside your heart? It feels like you're way behind than others, and you're being bullied by everyone ahead of you. Like you don't belong here, or something? All I have are these negative thoughts. Isn't it awful that I can't sleep properly without anyone by my side? Or is it that I'm the only lost kid in the world of grown-ups?"

"Don't talk about such things now. You've suffered a lot. So, just have a warm rest and focus on me for now. Okay?"

"Mhmm.... Okay."

"I love you, babe."

"Mhmm...."

"Oh God! It's **9** a.m. already. I have to go now. I'm getting late for work. Thank you for today. I feel so happy."

"Me too. You should get ready now."

"When you'll return from work, I'll make sure that you remember today's evening for your whole life. I'll see you soon."

"Really? Okay, I'm very excited now. See ya later, babe."

And thus, she left the apartment and headed towards her work. The scenario hadn't changed at all. The identical mornings for Jason had begun again for two consecutive days. It felt like Jason had forgotten or forced himself to forget everything that happened to him before meeting her. Perhaps it was something that no one was aware of. For now, the only thing he wanted to remember was the perfect birthday plan for his girl. And thus, Jason started to plan a perfect evening for her.

One might have numerous opinions and clarifications about certain topics, but when it comes to **love**, the perspective is empirical. Love is the ultimate need for a human being. People expect the love they desire from someone, but at the same time, it is all just about dumb luck. The hope for love may have a dreadful outcome, but mutual love is fortunate. It must be tragic that you sometimes communicate with a wall, and there's no understanding between them. It is fair to say that only understanding is not the key to a healthy relationship, but comprehension is. Love can be perplexing at times, but it does not imply that someone is destined to be alone forever. For those who have had a bitter experience of love, the opinions are vastly out of the ordinary. However, hope is such a delightful thing that tends to develop growth in humans. There is someone who is looking for you somewhere, someone who is waiting for you far from the current time and place, and someone will eventually find you. The fruit of patience will eventually deliver a sweet taste of fortunate love. Also, having said that, love can be found in the simplest of things. There is a strong desire to smile with loved ones, to giggle with them, and to make them feel special, for no reason at all. It's not that there's no logical reasoning in love at all. In crucial times, it is an absolute necessity, but love doesn't have to be logical all the time. **Sometimes, love defies logic. It's simply an eternal magic.** Love is the passion to share themselves with each other, to explore growth in contentment and crisis, and to commit to living together forever. However, one must not tend to complicate love for their sake.

Naturally, it was, of course, Jason's turn to love and be loved. The love he never wished for, but the fortunate love he was gifted was what he never expected from his life. He treasured that magical feeling, and the prospect of his timeless romance kept him going. Jason's long-dormant, unseen, and hidden enthusiasm resurfaced beneath his heart, and the way he followed his heart was a joyous view to witness. He was looking forward to his girl's birthday and had already begun to gather everything within his means for the sake of a wonderful night.

To begin, he decided to rearrange and decorate the hall in preparation for the occasion. First, he began by relocating the couch to the left corner, directly in front of the speakers and television. He began to slowly lift the couch and drag it across the carpet. If he had rushed, he would have damaged the carpet. He was, however, unusually cautious about those matters. He was soon satisfied with how perfect the arrangement appeared through his proud eyes, admiring his own work. Second, he decided to write her a poem, read it aloud to express his deepest feelings for her, and end with a beautiful song to reflect her importance in his life. The young man had always dreamed to live his life as if it were a romantic novel. It was only a few minutes away from being true, but he was skeptical of his luck. Anyway, he began composing a poem for her. It was surprising that it took him less than a few minutes to complete the poem. He had always loved to write since his school days. When he'd get amazed with joy, he would paint in his colorful journal. Also, when he'd was down, he would often pour all of his tears into that book.

It was all possible because of how supportive and encouraging Sera was. Jason's back was always shielded by Sera's love and care for him. The little boy was still alive somewhere inside his adult body, but there were no signs of it whatsoever. After he completed his poem, he picked a beautiful song for her too. Finally, he was certain that almost all the preparations were about to be fulfilled. The night he dreamed of was just a few steps away.

"All those hours of work, and now we're talking. Everything is set for tonight. I bet she will remember this as long as we live. I want to see you so much," the impatient breeze of a happy ending flew inside his mind.

"Oh shit. I haven't prepared anything for dinner." Jason suddenly realized.

He rushed towards the kitchen to prepare something for tonight. The moment he unlocked the refrigerator, he was stunned to witness the vacant space with just rotten tomatoes, a couple of eggs, and a few basil leaves. He was clueless as to how underwhelming the situation was.

"Now that we have no groceries, I guess I'll just order something from outside."

"Where's my phone? Damn it, where did I keep it?"

"Forget about it. I'll just get the groceries for tonight by myself. Oh shit! I almost forgot about cakes and candles. Gotta hurry up before she arrives." Jason rushed to the market.

An unwieldy attempt to celebrate a desperate evening was just one hour and forty-five minutes away. His heart and mind would have attained peace for a while if this night went perfectly fine.

"Shit! I forgot the umbrella. I hope this shitty rain won't begin all of a sudden."

** *One hour and fifteen minutes remaining* **

Jason rode for fifteen minutes to the station, which housed the city's primary market. Just as he was leaving the station, it began to pour aggressively.

"Come on. Are you kidding me?"

"I fucking hate this season."

He became enraged very soon, as usual, and let the loud claps of thunder and the shrieks of showers reflect his unwavering resentment. Even after his terrible experience with the rain, Jason hurried to the market entrance, where he had originally planned to start his shopping for the evening. With Halloween in full swing, the newly painted walls at the market entrance, the sparkling lights in the hallway and on the ceiling, the large group of locals encircling the entire square entryway, and the overall atmosphere created by the theatrical productions, musical performances and lively selections of stalls and cuisine, vividly depicted the local modern culture residing there. For those who had paid more than a few dollars, a lengthy night full of entertainment and activities had been commenced; nevertheless, the down streets were much darker, with almost any light or sound. They had never wished for a miraculous event to occur, nor could they afford the luxury. This is how simplistically the society aimed to create a contrasting viewpoint, showing how the worlds of the affluent and the indigent are different.

"I just need to find something special, like a chocolate cake or maybe even cheese cakes and brownies. I suppose some candles and balloons would be nice addition as well." Jason cautiously stored the information.

On his way while searching for a bakery, Jason started to notice the change in the background. An excruciating pain had suddenly developed inside his head. The background noise gradually began to decrease from its previous louder level. His ears were completely numb, and his mind was filled with disturbing and noisy resonating frequencies that bothered him. It was already affecting his vision and consciousness. Out of the blue, the noise inside his head vanished all of a sudden. It was a state of complete silence when an unknown voice paved its way to his ears.

"Jason.... Jason...." The voice resonated from somewhere nearby and accomplished to reach inside his head.

The past was repeated. He heard the same mysterious, crumbled voice as the day before. The identical timing could have been a coincidence. After a few minutes of the sunset, he began to hear all of those sounds, which led to all of the bizarre events that have occurred to this day.

"Jason.... Jason...."

"Come to me...."

"Find me, Jason...."

"You can not escape from yourself...."

"Jason.... Jason.... Ja-"

This time, the voice suddenly stopped. Jason found himself in the center of the square hall, but it wasn't long enough for his conscious mind to notice an outrageous change, and he found himself alone there.

He stood there for a while, with an expression of bewilderment on his face. He was analyzing himself and trying to make some sense of the situation.

"What the hell happened?" The irritating noises, an unknown voice, and now this? There were people, lights, music, and other things not long ago, and now I'm the only one here. Did the party come to an end? Did everyone return home? No, even if the program has ended, the decorations must be removed. What exactly is going on? What's the matter with me? Is this a dream? Am I ill? I feel like puking." Jason began to feel seriously ill.

"I should concentrate on the cake and candles." I'm running out of time. She'll be there in about twenty-five minutes. This is so frustrating. Let me quickly search where the bakery-" When he observed a menacing sight across his path, Jason was left speechless and with an expression of dread in his eyes. The look in his face shifted dramatically.

Abruptly, what shocked Jason was not an abomination from an horrific phenomenon or something out of this world, but an ordinary old brown door. The **recurring dream** for few weeks, finally answered the call. The moment he saw the door, an old growing up memory flashed before his eyes; a memory that had previously plagued him for a number of years, a memory that had taken a few crucial years of his childhood, and the same memory that he had kept inside his heart, forbidden from everything, came to light. The recollections from the past had begun to play in the back of his head. At that precise moment, the hideous show, worth enduring with the reel of fear for the rest of his life, arose from an escaping time.

Inside his head, a rumbling noise distorted, and he ultimately threw it all off. His mental wellness had been triggered by the breeze of overwhelming grief through the air of melancholy, which had almost covered his sleeves, but all of a sudden, his head was free of those bizarre things. Everything he saw a few minutes ago just happened to appear inside his miserable head within the blink of an eye. Then he reappeared in the middle of the crowd, realizing that he was simply suffering for no reason, breaking a few minor scars or two. However, the visual collection of those terrifying memories was not a delusional epitome. While he moved normally with everyone else at the end of the hall, he eagerly wanted to get some sleep as soon as he got home, but he had plans that were his primary concern for the day. The incentive he needed right now wasn't quite so straightforward, but the tasks he opted for were impeding his path. Finally, he sat himself down on a bench next to the elevator and relaxed for a few moments.

** *Fifteen minutes remaining* **

"Hey! Do you guys have a chocolate cake? Or may be anything similar to it, like brownies or even cheesecake? It's for a birthday celebration."

"Yeah! Sure. I'll bring it right away. Just give me 5 minutes, sir."

"Okay. I'm in a hurry, so please make it simple and as fast as possible. Also, I need some candles and balloons with it."

"Okay, sir. Please wait patiently."

"Patiently, huh?" He silently whispered with a sly leer towards the baker.

While he waited for his order, he started to question the purpose of such a wild, sudden experience back at the hall.

"No, no, no. This is not a dream. Everything that I saw was real. Why did I see all of that back there? After all these years, after all this time? What's wrong with me? ** Sir! ** Why is it so scary? ** Sir! ** Why? ** Hello? ** Why? ** Sir? ** Wh...."

"Sir? Is there something bothering you?" The owner woke Jason from his overthinking.

"Nah.... No. I'm alright. Sorry. Is my order ready?"

"Yes, it is. That's why I'm here to inform you."

"Great! How much is it?"

"Sir, I'll prepare the bill for you. Meanwhile, please go to the counter for information that we need to mention on top of the birthday cake. It would be better if you speak directly to my employee."

"Yeah. Thank you."

—

"Hello sir. Good evening. I just need to know the name of the birthday person. Is she your wife?"

"Nah, she's my girlfriend, but thank you."

"Sorry for my manners, sir."

"No. It's fine."

"I don't mind at all."

"Okay, sir. So, what's her name?"

"Yes. Very well. Ahem, her name is, yeah. Her name is.... her name.... her name....her name?"

It was finally time to face the harsh reality. The truth, which was revealed even though Jason was nonetheless unknown at that point, had finally come to light. Except for the two days that followed, the person Jason recognized as his girlfriend had no memories of her with him in the past. At that exact moment, he felt like the ground beneath his feet was slowly devouring all of his faith and drive. There was still a question in his head, and it seemed obvious that his doubt related to her true identity. It was all a lie to his spine after all this time. It only took a few seconds to sever the last of his hopes. The night for Jason was something even one doesn't want their enemies to suffer. The hellish agony was beyond imagination.

"Sir?"

"Sir?...."

"Excuse me, sir? What's wrong?"

"....." Jason kept staring at the cake.

"What's her name, sir?"

"Sorry. It was a misunderstanding."

"I don't get it, sir."

"I don't have a girlfriend...." He walked out of the store silently, addressing his words in a miserable voice.

PART-2

CHAPTER IV

THE MISSING PIECES

So far, Jason had already been through a hell of awful events leading to this exact moment where he had already neglected to search for a purpose and meaning of his life. The night wasn't just excruciatingly painful for him; he was totally impassive. The scars were certainly affecting him from within; however, the answers that could cure him were nowhere to be discovered. The young man appeared less enlivened and more like a pity walking corpse. The primary difference between him and the actual corpse was that the dead were free of purpose, events of suffering and terrible recollections, and the only reason they existed inside the coffin was to fulfill the role of a never-ending, never-waking sleep. Such a contrast in comparison is absurd for being assigned, whether to an innocent, a sinner, or a naive person. He was deeply crushed by the unimaginable misery, and he even considered carrying it all with him on his journey to his grave, someday in the future. His heart was aching for answers at the moment, but before that, it was a storm of fury that kept him alive, stumbling in the unknown dark streets for the sole purpose of surviving the night. In other words, he was more enraged than the monsoon itself. It was him, standing between his sanity and stability.

** *Sound of a telephone ringing somewhere* **

"Hello? Doc? Are you there?" inquired the girl.

"**Maze**? Is that you?" the doctor asked back.

"Yes. It's me. Where're you?"

"I'm on my way out of the hospital. What happened? Is everything okay?"

"No. Nothing's okay. Jason went missing yet again. He wasn't there when I arrived home. I told him to patiently wait for me, but he was attempting to surprise me for my birthday night. That must imply that he went somewhere to buy me presents for tonight. Gosh! I'm such an idiot. I've been searching for him for more than an hour and have looked around the neighborhood, but he's nowhere to be found. What should I do?" She started weeping aloud.

"Don't worry. We'll find him at any cost. Where're you? Tell me where're you exactly right now?"

"I am close to the market right now. I am about to look for him there. Maybe he heard the noises from the event tonight, and went there?"

"Very good. That could be the case. Okay, so let's do one thing. You go to the market as soon as possible and explore every nook and cranny, while I head to the bridge where the market ends. I'll be looking for him near the bridge and then through all of the back streets leading to the market's exit. I'll call you immediately as soon as I find him. Don't worry; we'll track him down. Let's get started."

"Okay. I'll be right there. I'll call you if I find him first." She hung up the phone, wiped her face, and dashed to the market.

"Damn it. This is really terrible. And most importantly, this is entirely my own mistake. I shouldn't have told him that today was my birthday. Gosh! I am such an idiot. You would have been safe if I had not been so reckless, Jason. Please stay safe until I find you, and I swear I'll never leave you alone again." Maze disclosed this to herself as she strode towards the market.

Meanwhile, the doctor was frustrated too. This was clearly something that he had not expected to happen.

"Why does this keep happening to me only? And, most importantly, why does Jason have to suffer so much? He's just a young man between the ages of **20** and **25** who needs to gain some normal experiences right now. Surely, God is being harsh on this poor soul. I wonder how difficult it is for Maze as well." Those intense thoughts troubled the doctor on his way to the bridge.

Jason, on the other hand, was constantly wandering through the gloomy streets, traveling down a straight, steady, and muddy road with no intention of ever stopping and no idea where the path led. Jason was depressed, so he paid barely any attention to his surroundings. There was a reason why the street used to be entirely pitch black at night, with no lights whatsoever. The street was notorious for its insecurity, criminal record, and history of dangerous activities and events. Similarly, Jason was at risk as well. Sometimes there would be a few prostitutes pursuing him, and other times there were some drug addicts, intoxicated individuals, alcoholics, smokers, and similar individuals attempting to get into an argument with him given that he was a total stranger there.

"Hey you! Watch yourself. Where'd you think you are going, bastard?" shouted from the crowd.

"He is completely ignoring you. You sound like a complete idiot," replied his friend.

"Hey you, blue eyes. I'm talking to you."

"Wait, you fucking piece of shit. I asked where're you going?.... Are you lost?.... Never saw you here before?.... Are you a cop or from the department?" A rowdy man grabbed Jason from his shirt's collar, in a irritated and noisy manner. But, Jason was silently lost in his own world. He had not recovered yet from his trauma.

"He ain't responding to you. Is he high or something?"

"Nah, probably he is not scared of him. Haha! This proves that no one is scared of you."

"Haha exactly. He is just full of words only."

"What do you expect? He is such a pussy."

The crowd started to mock him.

"Shut up, you idiots. I'll make him talk."

"Now, you're dead. I'll slaughter you like a pig, you son of a b..." The man was interrupted by an **alcoholic** from the crowd.

"Yo! There's no need for such fuss. Leave this man alone and piss off, fool."

"Who the hell are you now? This has nothing to do with you. Leave my hand, you ..."

"Yo! Yo! Yo!...."

The alcoholic man slapped the young hooligan so hard that others from his gang were shocked to witness.

"Ahh shit! I think that was a hard one."

"I wonder if he would even remember any of this."

One of the members from his gang dragged him towards the van. Others were stunned to witness how easily the drunk man slammed their member. All of a sudden, the noisy loud atmosphere drastically shifted to those of a library. The drunk man was quite flashy for a moment.

"You'll get in trouble if you create your own mess. How many times did I tell you to not create a scene?" argued with the drunk man.

"Go tell him. He was the one who tried to punch me. It was just an act of self defense. It's not my fault."

"Yeah sure." His friends laughed at his silly explanation.

"Where did that fellow go?" asked the drunk man.

Surprisingly, Jason didn't even realize that he was about to get beaten a few minutes ago. He didn't even notice anything happened. It was just him, his blurry vision, and his broken heart. Everything was so fucked up for him, until the drunk man forced Jason to listen his talk.

"You okay, lad?" The drunk man called Jason by hitting him on his back.

"Are you lost? I have never seen you before. Where're you from? I don't think you really belong ...."

"Don't bother talking to me. You've no role here. Know your place." Jason stared at the man with his menacing blue eyes.

"Yo, what's with that scary face? What's wrong? Did I do something weird? Did I say something weird?" The drunk man started thinking inside his head.

"Mind your own business. I don't care what you want, but the only thing I could give you is a mere taste of disappointment and rage. So, don't bother."

"Yo, scary. This man is truly broken from inside. What could be the reason?"

"Hey, come back. It's getting late. The cops will be here soon. Hey Ol...."

"Yo! Yo! Okay. Just give me a moment."

"Hey young man. At least tell me what's your name?"

"Yo. Yo blue eyed man. Yo tall fellow."

The drunk man chased Jason until both of them finally reached near the bridge.

"Yo. Don't ignore me like that. It hurts."

Jason silently stood there as if the man was invisible to him.

"He's really something. I guess something tragic might have happened to him? Disappointment? Rage? It only makes sense now."

"Yo, man. Whatever happened to you, it must be painful. I won't say that I can feel your disappointment or rage or anything, but I can surely say that you are not alone in this world who went through such emotions."

And hence, the man started talking to Jason, but he had ignored him since their first encounter.

"Yo! Let me introduce myself. My name is **Oliver**. Yes, it is only Oliver. You might find it odd that I don't have a surname. Everyone got used to it, and you will, too, eventually. I don't have a surname because I am entirely alone. I grew up as an orphan. I've spent my entire life by myself. I have no idea where I was born or who my parents are. I've been a wanderer on the streets since I was a child. Before I realized I was homeless, these streets became my home, and the people on these streets became my people.

Those are my people back there, yo. We're all wanderers on the streets. This is our home, and we enjoy living here. Everyone here calls me '**Ol**'. You can call me that as well. I've been in this city for nearly **40** years. Maybe more or less, but I'm not sure about that because I don't know when I was born, haha. At the very least, this drink tells me nothing whatsoever. Haha! That's one way to put it: I'm an alcoholic freak. But I wasn't always this way. I never used to be an alcoholic. I don't want to be one either right now. But right now, I can't help but think of myself as a freak. The bottle in my hand, joined me a few years ago before I even realized why I needed to consume it.

I started drinking entirely to remember my love and cry in her memories. Yes, a few years ago, I was in love. It was wonderful to be in love. I used to forget everything that existed when I was with her, and I was solely under hypnosis in her presence. It was a timeless spell. Love was a magical experience for me. Let me start from the beginning. So, a few years ago, I was a young guide in downtown. I knew every street in the city because I was a wanderer on the street. So I decided to earn some cash from this. Then this one evening, we met. It was raining the entire night. Also, the monsoon season in this city is extremely severe. So, that night, I was counting my earnings near a food stall, and she sat next to me. She was such a lovely young lady. Her hair was wet and fussy, and her eyes seemed pretty worried... Worried, may be about the monsoon... Worried, may be about the cold winter... Worried, may be about the new place. I had no idea what her eyes wanted to show me. But I was certain that her eyes showed me heaven on earth.

I was madly in love with her before I even realized it. I used to spend my days fantasizing about our future. She used to appear in my dreams, surprising me even in the middle of the night. It wasn't that I had never seen a more beautiful woman than her, but I don't know why I couldn't take my eyes off her. Days and weeks passed, but I couldn't forget her. And one day, I decided to track her down and tell her how much I loved her. I, along with my friends, searched for days, but we couldn't find her. Deep down, I was sad. I assumed I would never see her again. I assumed I'd lost her forever. However, I saw her at the food stall again a week later, when the rain was exactly the same as the last time. She left the stall before I could say anything to her. So, I followed her because I wanted her to know what I felt for her. I wanted to express my feelings to her. She soon arrived at her house. Meanwhile, I had followed her the entire distance, so it would have been a waste if I'd returned without saying anything. So I decided to call her out through the window. But then, everything went terribly wrong. Everything I saw there threw the whole thing into disarray. I noticed her with another man. They were kissing each other naked, completely immersed in their own romance. I was extremely disappointed. It's a really horrible feeling, when you don't get what you desire. It's upsetting to see someone happy with something that you've wanted for a long time. It broke my heart. I was so disappointed that I considered suicide. Everything seemed pointless to me. All my hopes had been dashed when I saw her with another man, and she was so happy that I had no chance of fitting in the picture, not even in the background."

At this point, Jason was silently listening all of this, but he had no interest to react on his tale.

“The rage was so intense that I lost control of my mind and body. After seeing that from the window, all I could remember next is their bloody room." The word '**blood**' jolted Jason out of his trance. After hearing what the man had said, Jason's eyes were even scarred enough to blink.

“Yo! I **murdered** them...” There was a brief moment of silence, all of a sudden.

"Yo, I remember now. Hahaha! Everything is crystal clear in my mind. There was an axe in their garden. I carried the axe into their room and murdered them. First, I severed the man's arms, which had touched her. I couldn't resist someone else touching her. I was so satisfied to hear his screams. Following that, I chopped off his head. Observing that horror left the girl numb. Her lovely eyes gradually began to resemble those of a filthy old lady. Everything was a lie. The lies that her beauty demonstrated to me were disappointing. It was a huge letdown that I had to pry her eyes out of her face. Oh, and I slashed her all over her naked body. She had the audacity to strip naked in front of another man. Only I have the right to see her naked. Nobody else will be able to have her. Only I have the right to love her. Only I have-“ Jason smacked the drunk man on the head and knocked him out. Jason was fully aware of his surroundings after hearing everything the man said. Jason had to hear all of those things, which was very disturbing. He then realized that an alcoholic freak who saved his life turned out to be a maniac. He was casually conversing with a murderer. He felt relieved to see the man on the ground.

"Clap... Clap... Clap...." Jason heard someone clapping as they approached him.

"You're something else, Jason. I suppose God has placed the entrance of misfortune and horror right in your laps. Even I could't withstand such absurdity." The doctor heard their conversations and humored him.

"Who are you?" inquired Jason.

"This isn't our first time. Well, I am Dr. **Dave Dowski**. I am a **retired surgeon** and a **psychiatrist**. I've a clinic near the hospital located in downtown. Also, you're my **client**."

"Client? What client?"

"I am sure I have to tell you a lot. Please come with me. I'll introduce myself clearly on the way to my house. But before that, have these freshly made sandwich. You are very hungry, aren't you?"

Jason had no choice but to take it, as he had no idea what might have happened if he didn't knock the drunkard.

"Enjoy your meal in my car. Just give me a moment."

The doctor called Maze to inform that Jason is safe and sound for now.

"Hello? Maze?"

"Hello? Doc? What's the update?"

"I have good news for you. Jason is safe and I am bringing him to my place.""

"Great. Thank god, he's safe."

"Where are you?

"I am not that far from your house. I will be on my way to your house. Keep him safe, doc. And also, thank you for everything." Maze hung up the call and rushed to Dave's house.

The rain appeared out of nowhere once more, warning that mayhem could possibly break out. Dave and Jason quickly departed from the bridge, taking with them a disturbing memory of the drunk man. Jason began to see things inside his head again as they drove. And this time, the same anonymous door reappeared.

“Argh! ....” Jason screamed in agony.

“What’s wrong? Is it the dream again?”

“Argh! ....”

“Yes! ....”

“Hang on for a bit. We’re about to reach my home.”

“Hang on....”

"The dose seem to have an effect. I'm not sure what happened to him, but he recently suffered from something. I'll take him to the hospital tomorrow, but first I need to make sure he doesn't forget anything from today, yesterday, or the days before that.” Dave infused the drug into his sandwich in order to relax his mind, but the side effects outweighed the dose.

On the other hand, Jason was going through an intense psychological battle inside his head. He had to go through a terrifying ordeal. The obscure door appeared in front of him, and all he could hear were voices from within. The anonymous voices stumbled and began to call his name.

"Jason.... Jason...."

"You must find me...."

"Jason.... You must be aware of the truth.... You must seek the truth..."

"Jason.... Jason...."

"Jason.... Jason...."

"Jason! Jason!" Dave yelled his name at him to wake him up. After several attempts to rouse him, he was forced to inject the drug into his body for the final time. Thanks to Dave's drugs, Jason managed to regain his consciousness.

"We've arrived, Jason. You must be confused. Let's have a proper conversation, shall we?"

** *After they reached Dave's house* **

Finally, Dave told him everything in precise detail that was needed to be told, including his earliest symptoms and his long-term, on-going mental illness. In fact, the doctor had known Jason for quite a while now. They had some pasts that Jason had forgotten about. All he knew at that moment was about his current overall well-being, and it was not easy for him to comprehend that he was mentally unstable.

"One year? Seriously?"

"Yes. You've been seeing things for more than a year. I have known you for quite a while now."

"I don't get it. How is this possible?"

"Calm down, Jason. It's gonna be alright."

"How the hell am I supposed to remain calm? I had no recollection of being a mentally unstable freak until yesterday, and now you show up just a few hours ago and tell me that I'm sick? What exactly do you expect me to do? Huh? Take it all in like it's nothing. That's simply not how it works, old man. My entire world has changed. What the hell is the matter with you? How am I supposed to behave like a normal person? Answer me, old man."

"Right. Take it easy for a while. Panic will get you nowhere. I understand that this is difficult for you to fully comprehend. But the harsh reality is that you are mentally ill. Furthermore, it would be fair enough to state that your **hallucinations** have grown significantly over the last three months."

"Hallucinations?"

"Yes, Jason."

"What do you mean?"

"Calm down, Jason."

"Just tell me, old man. Just tell me what the hell do you mean."

"Fine. Relax and listen."

"Okay, let me explain in simple terms so that you will understand. In some instances, the patient starts to think about specific scenarios; it's similar to living according to your desires and such. They become so accustomed to their own world that they forget about the existence of reality itself. Everything that matters to them is their imaginary world, and they develop the illusion that they only belong in that world. Despite the fact that their activities have little to do with reality, they might leave an impact on their surroundings on a small to large scale, depending on the level of their imaginations. This is just one of a few episodes that can be treated to some extent. What I've talked about are the most common and potentially harmless kinds of hallucinations. Patients with such episodes recover after a few months of surveillance, therapy, and medication. However, your situation is unique. It's unlike anything I've ever seen.

Every case of **hallucination** has a particular **trigger** or incidents that tend to **provoke** or might impact the entire **abnormality**. It could be caused by past experiences, or it could be an outcome of stress or anxiety. Also, it could be related to the patient's early years, a few traumatic events, or some awful experiences. Most of the time, we consult with the patient's parents or relatives to determine the root cause and work to resolve it. And those cases have improved, if not returned to normalcy. However, I haven't discovered any particular cause of your hallucinations. I'm afraid to tell you that I have no idea when your illness began. We first met at the downtown market more than a year ago. When I first saw you in the market, you were standing close to the entrance, looking like a statue. I was wondering what you were up to. So I attempted to communicate with you.

“Is everything okay? I noticed you that you’re standing here for a few minutes now. Are you lost, young man?”

“....”

“Hello? What’s the matter?”

“....”

“Do you hear me? Hello?”

And suddenly, you went unconscious and fell there on the spot. After a few minutes, you woke up with no recollection of when or how you got there in the first place.

"That's much better. At long last, you've opened your eyes."

"What happened?" Where exactly am I? "Who are you?"

"Well, you just fell a minute ago. Don't you remember?”

“No. I don’t.”

It was strange to witness how quickly someone's mind forgot an incident that had occurred a moment before. I was curious back then, but I had a lot of work to do, so I didn't pay much attention to it. However, this wasn't our only meeting. A week later, I saw you sitting near a bakery, just like before. I waved at you. But you also had no recollection of meeting me before. That's when you had my full attention. That day, I assigned **Maze** to look after you. She followed you wherever you went and took notes on what you did every day, the individuals you encountered, the places you visited, and so on. She then used to keep me up-to-date on all of your daily activities. She did a good job stalking you until one day you noticed her following you. Then you pursued her, which led you to the hospital, where I was waiting for you. Everything went smoothly. Our objective was to entice you into my clinic so that I could get an improved understanding of your situation. And everything went off without a hitch, just as I had hoped. Since then, you've been my longest and most difficult patient. After doing a little digging, I discovered your name, address, family, occupation, social connections, and some information about your past. And then, I came to know that you used to live somewhere near the valley with Se-"

"Wait!.... What caused all of this? Why me?"

"A year and more have passed, and even though I did my best to understand and treat your mental illness, I have yet to identify the origin of your episodes. Ahh! It's been a difficult journey for all of us, especially for Maze. Honestly, she had the most tough role. You should cherish her efforts, Jason."

“Having said that, you shouldn't be excessively worried. I'm nevertheless giving it my all. So, do you get it now?”

“Jason? Are you okay?”

“....”

“Why aren’t you responding? Huh! Are you experiencing another psychotic episode? Calm down, Ja....”

“Not that.... Just don’t talk for a while.”

“So?....”

“Why me?”

“Huh?....”

“Why did this happen to me? What’s my fault?”

“There’s no fault, Jason. It’s just that....”

"But why me?” Jason screamed.

“Why in the world is it me? What exactly did I do to deserve this? Now, my entire life is fucked up. Now that I think about it, I can't remember anything at all. Not yesterday, not the day before, not a few months ago, and I don't know—maybe years and years before you even noticed me. Even this morning felt both refreshing and perplexing at the same time. It makes sense now. Damn it. I'm not sure how long I've been down with illness or whatever. Why me? What went wrong with me? Why? Why? Why?....” Jason began punching the walls and crying out in frustration.

Even Dave was helpless. He couldn't do anything but watch Jason sob. As a medical professional, it was difficult for him as well. The only case that had bothered him to this extent in his entire career was none other than Jason's. The grizzling thunder and the cloudburst laughing at Jason's agony made the situation as terrible as it could possibly be.

"Arghhh...." Jason screamed as he went through another episode.

"What's wrong, Jason?"

** *The obscure door reappeared* **

"Jason.... Jason...."

"Find me.... You should be aware of the truth.... You must seek the truth.... You must seek the answers...."

Then, in quick succession, he began to observe an uninterrupted series of distorted and unidentified visuals, gloomy and dark locations, the river of blood, people screaming, an old, broken cottage, and various other scenes like these. The pressure was far too much for Jason's body to endure. His body had to give up at the end. Jason then collapsed to the ground, and his body began to vibrate erratically. It was a terrifying sight to witness.

"Damn it. Hang on, I'll get the injections from my car." Dave rushed to his cars to get the syringe to calm his mind. He carried a set of anti-psychotic medications and some painkillers with him, just to be cautious.

** *Jason puked while vibrating* **

"Here, here. Here you have it." Dave injected Jason with his medication to finally calm him down after the incident. Jason regained consciousness after a few seconds.

"Take a long, deep breath. Relax. Get up."

"Take it easy."

"I think that's enough for today."

"Take these pills along with a painkiller. Now I'll give you a dose to ensure that you don't forget about today."

"Why?...."

"Just take these pills. Hurry up; this will come in handy."

"Does this have any side effects?"

"It depends on how much stress you put on your mind. The more quickly you relax, the more feasible it is for them to work."

Jason took the pills with trepidation, fearful of the recurring episode.

"Now, just calm down and don't think about it for a while."

Soon, Maze interrupted Dave as he attempted to change the subject.

"Jason!.... Where is he?" Maze gasped in relief as she ran all the way from the market, which was roughly four or five miles from Dave's house. Finally, they crossed paths again. And subsequently, the symphony of all those terrible memories started playing inside his head. After realizing that the girl's identity was unknown to him and concluding that she was not his girlfriend, the girl whom Jason suspected finally showed up in front of him. Jason was brimming with rage and answers at the time.

"You are okay." Maze ran towards Jason, weeping, to hug him.

"Thank God, you're all right. I was terrified that I had lost you. Why did you leave? You should have waited until I arrived. You're such a moron. Why did you leave without telling me? Please never leave me alone. Don't ever make me sad again. Please don't abandon me, okay? Please-"

"Hey! Who exactly are you? Tell me, who are you?"

“Huh?" Jason pushed Maze furiously. Jason's rage took control of his emotions.

"Who the fuck are you? Do you realize how much I suffered because of you? What made you do this to me? Why, for God's sake?.... How many nights and days did I spend with an unknown girl like you? Did you enjoy it? Because it is most certainly hell for me. Tell me who you the fuck are. "

"Jason. Relax"

“Don’t talk, old man. This is completely between us."

"Jason.... Please don't yell at me like that-”

“Don’t talk. Just tell me who the fuck are you, bitch-“

"You moron. Behave yourself.” Dave slapped Jason.

“She’s my assistant, Maze. She is the one I mentioned to you. She has been looking after you for over a year. You don't know her anymore because of your illness. I am certain it is not amnesia, but rather a short-term memory loss caused by the stress and load placed on your brain as a result of your psychosis. Your brain can no longer function normally as it once did. After you go to sleep, your brain forgets everything. A few crucial details might trigger fragments of your memories but that’s not it. That sleep refreshes your brain, and when you wake up the next day, you're completely blank. That's why you didn't know who she was. I don't know what happened to you, and I have no idea why you're angry, but she has nothing to do with any of this. She does not deserve any of this. You should apologize to her right away. Move and don’t you dare return without her."

** *A few minutes later* **

It was 2 a.m. at midnight. Dave dashed out of the house to find Maze and apologize to her. Jason walked for a few minutes only to find her sobbing on a park bench. Jason felt awkward at first, but the guilt in his heart compelled him to apologize.

"Hey.... I'm sorry...."

"...."

"I'm truly sorry about everything that I said."

"Don't talk to me. I hate you."

"Yeah! Okay. Well, I deserve that. So, the old man explained everything to me, and now I feel bad for hurting you. I'm deeply sorry, Maze. Please forgive me."

Maze turned towards Jason, held his hand, and started punching him.

"I hate you."

"Okay."

"I hate you. I hate you. I hate you."

"Got it. I hear you. It's okay to hate me." She still continued her punches, but slowly, they became harmless.

"Let's get inside. It's starting to get cold."

"Mhmm.... No...."

"Come on!...."

"Mhmm.... No...."

"Please?...."

"Mhmm.... If you say so...."

"I'm sorry for hurting you. I'll take care of it next time."

"Mhmm...."

"Okay." Jason patted her hair softly.

"Promise me that you'll never yell at me like this."

"Sure. I promise."

"Promise me that you'll never forget about me."

"I promise."

"Promise me that you'll never leave me again."

"Never.... I promise."

"And.... promise me that you'll always be mine."

"I promise...."

"Okay." Unknowingly, their conversation healed each other. Maze began to feel a lot better, and Jason was also relieved of stress for a while. Even if Jason had no memories of her or their past, the connection they shared was the strongest evidence of their bond. They were meant to be together forever, and nothing in the entire universe could separate these two lovers with a long history together. For them, it felt like home is not a place; it is people.

"Now, let's get going."

"Mhmm.... A little bit more..."

"We should hurry, Maze. It's getting cold out here."

"But you are warm. Let me hug you a little longer. Please let me stay by your side."

"Sure...." Despite the freezing temperature after the end of the drizzle, Jason embraced her more tightly for a while to calm her and cease her tears. It was the only time Jason's instincts were naturally optimistic about the monsoon. Maze's presence put his heart and mind at ease.

"Ahem!.... Ahem!.... Well, it's time to get inside, lovebirds."

Dave interrupted them with awkward timing.

"Don't embarrass us, old man."

"Both of you look so complete. It's brimming love. Look at you, you seem so happy, Maze."

"Stop it...."

"Haha! You look happy too, Jason. If Sera was alive, she would have thrown a party to celebrate this moment."

"Cut it out...."

"...."

"**If Sera was alive?.... Sera?.... Alive?**"

"**What did you say? Sera?**"

"**Yes.**"

"**Sera?....**"

"**Sera!....**"

** *Words stumbling before Jason's mind* **

"Jason.... Jason...."

"You must find me...."

You must be aware of the truth.... You must seek the truth.... Find the truth..."

"Find it.... Find the truth.... Find the door...."

"Jason.... Jason...."

"Argh...." Jason fell on the ground.

"Again? Jason, are you okay?"

"Jason! Doc, what is happening to him? Help him. He is screaming of pain. Do something."

"Another episode. But why now? I think Sera's name has triggered a memory from his past."

"Do something. He's not responding."

"Don't worry. He had already taken the dose so he won't forget any of this. Hang on, Jason."

And it all came back to the beginning. The name of Sera finally triggered a vague memory from his past. Inside his head, Jason saw Sera's body laying on the ground with blood all over it, and all of his agony haunted him for another time. The same memory in which Maze assisted Jason in recovering from such a horrible sight. Everything came to light, and once again, Jason became powerless to escape his past.

CHAPTER V

THE UNSPOKEN VERACITY

Four days of unforgettable encounters brought him straight back to the beginning of this entire bizarre sequence of chaos. The day he witnessed Sera's disturbing death had finally started to penetrate the back of his head. Everything he'd forgotten for these past few days had resurfaced, only to raise more doubts and leave scars on his already wounded soul.

** *An hour later* **

“Is he all right?"

“Yes, he is. It’s nothing like you think. He’ll be just fine."

"When? When will everything return to normal?"

"Calm down, Maze. There's no need to be worried."

"How am I supposed to remain calm, doc? How can I believe that everything is fine? How many more days will he have to suffer like this? How many more days will we have to suffer like this? I can't see him like this. I can't bear the thought of him forgetting everything one by one, and ultimately me too. I just can't lose him. I just can't." Maze couldn't keep it together any longer and burst into tears.

“....” Dave started to console Maze.

"Take good care of him. I'll go get some coffee for you.”

Jason had been in a lot of pain the entire time, but Maze felt his pain as well. It was a difficult period for everyone present. Nonetheless, they held out hope that their lives would return to normalcy very soon. Meanwhile, Jason awoke suddenly from his bed.

"Hey! It's me, babe. It's me."

"...." Jason gasped aggressively.

"What happened? Tell me."

"Where is he?"

"Doc?"

"Yeah him."

"I am here. How're you feeling?"

"You know Sera?"

"Yeah, about that...."

"You knew this entire time? How do you know about her? About us?"

"First, sit down. I've been through this countless of times. You have a lot of questions, and it's natural for you to have them. But trust me that nothing you remember is true. The truth is something else."

"What does that mean?"

"Just calm down and have a seat."

Jason starred at Dave for a while, however, it was Maze who told him to relax.

"Listen to him, Jason. Please sit down...."

"...." Jason did as Maze insisted.

"I know this might be strange, but could you explain me what did you see that night in the apartment? Whatever you saw isn't what actually happened."

Jason starred at both of them.

"Ahem.... When I walked in, I noticed that Sera's wrist had a severe cut, her eyes were completely white, her body remained still, she had marks on her arms and legs, and the floor was covered in blood and.... and...." Jason found it difficult to explain the details.

“And what about Maze? Where was she?”

“She was also there. She came after a few minutes.”

“....” Dave silently comprehended the situation.

“Okay. Now, listen to me very carefully, Jason. Whatever you witnessed that day was completely inside your head. Maze was with you that day, and she was fully aware that this isn’t what happened actually. The reality is something else.”

“Jason, we’re here for you. Please trust us.” Maze held Jason’s hands tightly, showing her care for him.

“I know it must be difficult for you as well, Maze, but I had to tell you this one day. Actually, what Jason told us about Sera when we first talked was not entirely accurate or complete. He revealed that he used to live with Sera after they moved to downtown from the valley. Well, this isn't entirely finished."

And, gradually, Dave revealed every detail about the relationship between Jason and Sera, as provided by Sera a few years ago.

"If my memory serves me well, my final encounters with Sera were roughly six years ago. It was one week before Christmas Eve. I recall it vividly because that was my final day at the hospital. The director, the owner, my friends, students and colleagues, and everyone at the hospital decided to farewell me, and Sera was there as well.

She abruptly confronted me inside my office after the farewell party had ended.

"Well, Well.... Congratulations to the man of the day—in fact, the pride of this hospital." Sera walked up to me.

"Sera? Long time. I didn't expect to see you here...."

"Haha, yeah. Your memory doesn't match that of a 56-year-old man. You truly are gifted."

"Don't flatter me like this."

"You earned it. Your efforts are still commendable. Especially the ones you did for victims of government illicit activities. Also, I'm surprised that this hospital is private."

"Well, I'm touched by your words. But tell me how did you remember me today? After all these years? Is it okay for you to be here?"

"I'm all right. No worries; I'm used to it now. Because of the news and press releases, the entire world believes that I am responsible for destroying that ward and murdering all of the children there...."

"Yeah. We couldn't do anything at that time..."

"Forget it right now. So, how about you? Are you willing to meet a murderer like me? Should I close the door? Should I also shut these windows?"

"I know you're not guilty. They held you responsible for all of their rubbish experiments and..."

"I'm fine now, and I'm not coming here for that. I have another thing to tell you. I'm here for your help."

"Tell me. What exactly is it?"

"No, not here. This is not a safe place to talk, and it's also very personal. For now, follow me. Let's talk about this at my place."

It wasn't a coincidence that she appeared unannounced in my office after all she had been through. So I followed her to find out what she had to say. It was hopeful to see her in such good health, even after so many years. The war had ended nearly 8 years ago, and life had returned to somewhat normal and peaceful levels. Also, it reminded me that Sera had been suffering for nearly 8 years. It must have been miserable for her.

"We've arrived...."

"Where? In the forest? Is this the safe place that you're talking about?"

"No worries; you can trust me. It's safe."

"But where?"

"Just follow me...."

As I followed her through the gloomy forest battling the cold-blooded wrath of snowy wind, we came near an old broken cottage, with barely any lights and windows.

"Be careful. We don't have lights in the passage."

"Of course, I'll be. Where did you bring me?"

"Just follow me."

"But the house is empty. Where shall I follow you?"

"Here.... This is the way to the basement."

"Honestly, what is all of this? You live here?"

"Yeah! It's sad that I can't have my freedom to live a normal life anymore. Come on, hurry up."

It was miserable to witness Sera's pitiful situation. She was utterly devastated on the inside. I met her in the valley when I was about **46** years old when I visited the ward for the first time. My brother was a high ranked officer for the government and he's the one who introduced me to her.

However, the Sera I knew no longer existed; rather, I noticed the back of a strong woman who had no regrets about her actions, as the result produced an outcome in which she abandoned everything for the biggest decision of her life. The decision to live in a way she had never anticipated, but still, the decision to live in the way she was living now showed just how firm her commitment was. And that decision was to protect you, Jason.

"Me?" Jason interrupted.

"Yes. You...." Dave responded.

** *Back to the past* **

"Me?" I questioned Sera.

"Yes. You...." Sera responded.

"Wait. What do you mean, he's ill? Explain again..."

"Like I said, he's sick from the inside."

"What's on the inside? Just clarify everything."

"Like he has no recollection of what happened a few days ago, and such.... His memories are a little hazy."

"Well, he's only a boy. That's not how you tell if he's okay or not."

"This is serious. I've noticed a shift in his demeanor. We had our first snowfall of this winter season a few days ago. I'm certain it was a moment worth remembering for us. However, when I asked him about his experience the next day, he had no recollection of it. Even yesterday, he began to act strangely toward me. I was scarred. I couldn't even ask for help either. So, after a lot of deliberation, I decided to visit you in the hope that you would be of assistance. "

"Okay.... But who's this kid?"

"Well...."

"Just tell me, will you?"

"Fine...."

"I'll be right back. Now, go to your bed like a good boy. Good night."

"Okay. I'll be waiting for you." A teen Jason responded to Sera.

That day was the first time when I got to see you, and the same day, I learnt a lot about you from Sera.

"That's it. So, do you get it now?" Sera told Dave everything about their lives since the incident.

"Yes.... But what happened to other children?"

"I managed to flee with three kids. One of them was shot in the head as I carried him on my right arm. The next thing I saw was his bloodied body lying on the ground as I continued to run. Shortly, when I was shot in my left hand, the second kid fell from my grip into the river. I had to watch her drown in front of me. To me, it felt like hell. I was so helpless that I had no time to even mourn for them. I witnessed their demise, which they did not deserve. It was the absolute worst."

"Sure, it was hell...."

"...."

"That's why I want him to be perfectly fine. I want him to be like everyone else. He'd been living in the shadows for years, but it wouldn't last forever. I don't want his life to be crushed beneath this cottage forever. I want the best for him. So, please help me."

"Mhmm...." I was left dazed after hearing Sera.

"Thank you for doing this."

"And what about you?"

"What about me?"

"What're you gonna do after you free the boy from the shadows?.... From your shadows...."

"Haha. Me? I think I'll just be near him, but not with him." Sera chuckled softly.

"What does that mean?"

"Let me share a true story from the time I was around fifteen years old. So, there was this girl I knew who had recently lost her parents and had come to stay with her affluent friend. Her friend, who had a radiant spirit and gentle kindness, had been there for her since the beginning. She lived with her father and brother in the mansion. Her mother used to travel a lot, so she would only come home during holidays and breaks. They were the wealthiest and most powerful family in the city, wielding influence and authority. No one dared to oppose them since their presence was overwhelming. Her friend's solid reputation made the girl feel safe in her presence.

One day, her friend and her father went to visit her mother. Thus, the girl had to stay in the house with her friend's older brother. And that night changed the girl's life forever. Her brother, who was already married and had two children, raped the girl multiple times. The girl screamed for help, but no one could hear her. When they got back the next day, the girl told her friend and her father everything that her brother had done to her. And you might think her friend, given the kind personality, assisted her, and her brother was punished. Right? Well, that wasn't the case.

After the girl revealed her condition, her friend suddenly slapped her and murmured into her ears, "So, you've finally shown your true self." The girl was traumatized by her friend's sudden behavior. The girl trusted and loved her friend more than anyone else, but it was unfortunate that her friend didn't feel the same way. "A weakling like you has no right to oppose us. Know your place," she continued to say to the girl. The father also punished the girl, saying, “You dare speak about us like that? You're a useless girl. You're a worm. A worm like you should know your place. You have absolutely no freedom to do anything.”

Since that day, the girl has been forced to work as a slave in the house. Every night, both her father and brother tortured her. Her friend, on the other hand, ignored the girl no matter what happened. It went on for weeks until she finally ran away from the house. Even after she escaped, they continued to search for her for several weeks. About a month later, she was well out of reach for them. It was such a shame that her trust was suddenly shattered. Everything she thought she knew turned out to be a big lie. Even after this incident, she had to go through a lot. Because the girl was poor and frail, she was helpless wherever she went. It took her a lot of effort to regain her self-confidence. Since then, the girl has only believed that if you are fragile, the world will crush your will and freedom. The girl became aware of her ability to be strong and free in order to survive. That incident opened her eyes, and her life has turned out to be very different from her bleak past. At least, it was for a few years before the cycle began to repeat itself. Being weak makes one feel sick, doesn't it?”

“Don’t overdo yourself....”

"Life is a never-ending field of possibilities. You won't know anything unless you confront it. It's like a race, and you keep running. You try to get there as fast as possible. You have to give it your all and strive to be faster than everyone else. You're forced to compete in this race, but it's a race that you have to win no matter what. It's a race against time and people. If you don't win them over, they won't hesitate to crush you. Over all these years, I've realized that the winners will take your freedom away from you. If you lose the race, no matter what you do, you will ultimately be crushed by the winners. I don't want that for him. I've gone through a lot just so he could attain the freedom I never had. I was a failure and a loser, but I want him to succeed. I want him to experience the real world, face it, and stand tall. I want him to live a life with freedom that he could understand. This place is a prison for him. He can only escape this place if I destroy it, just as the ward was destroyed.”

“But what about him? Have you ever asked what does he want? Will he be happy or not? Have you considered that?”

“Happiness is a choice. It's a decision. If you achieve the freedom you seek, you will be the happiest person in this world. I want Jason to be able to choose what he wants out of life, and in order to do so, he must first conquer the everyone from the race.”

"But what if the boy chooses you, Sera?"

"What if....? That's a possibility I don't want...."

“....”

"Let's get in. The fire is doused, and it’s freezing here....”

All I could sense was that she was ready with an answer to refute any questions that I asked. We argued a lot that night, even though our heated arguments reached the ceiling. But she never perceived things the same way I did, which created a schism between our points of view. It wasn't about winning or losing, but about her desperate attempt to free Jason from her predicament.

The next day, I decided to visit the basement to check on your health. Sera was waiting for me across the way beside a huge log, observing me and my briefcase.

“What’s with that briefcase?” Sera curiously questioned.

“Nothing much. It’s just some records, documents, and such. It’s just my way of work.”

“No surprise....”

“How’s the boy?”

“About that....”

“Did you notice something strange the other night?”

“Yes. Actually, it’s getting worst.”

“What happened?”

"Well, he has no memory of what happened yesterday." He forgot about the date, began acting strangely when he awoke, and doesn't recognize you at all. "What's going on with him?"

"Let me take care of this."

And then, when we got home, you weren't there. We looked everywhere for hours, but we were unable to locate you. Your absence devastated Sera. She was exhausted and lacked all energy. So, I made a decision.

"Don't worry. I'll track him down. It's freezing outside, so take care of yourself. I’ll search for him now.”

“No. I’ll come with you. I can’t just wait here....”

“You’re tired. You should rest.”

“How can I? No, I’m coming....”

"What if he returns home by taking the same route? Someone should be waiting for him here.

“But....”

“I'm going to search for him while you're here. Until then, stay strong.”

“Fine.... Return as soon as possible....”

“Don’t worry. We’ll find him.”

As a result, I left the place in search of you. Sera had been waiting for you by herself. I had no idea it would be the last time I would see her. After a few hours, I returned to the basement, hoping you'd already returned home. Instead, none of you were present. The door was locked, and a note was left next to the window. It was a note. An old message that continues to haunt me to this day. I still remember the note vividly. The message said something like, "*If you find Jason, take care of him. Don't bother looking for me.*" That marks the end of my encounter with Sera. She's gone missing for more than six years since that terrible evening.”

With the sole exception of Dave, everyone fell utterly silent, stunned to learn of such a massive event. As for Maze, she was more concerned about Jason. Meanwhile, Jason remained confined to his couch throughout his period of suffering.

“Jason? Are you okay?” Dave asked him.

“....”

“You won’t say anything?”

“....”

“You okay?” Maze attempted to comfort him.

"It's so messed up." Jason uttered it in a deep, solemn tone.

"It's such chaos. I almost forgot about her in an instant, until eventually I ended up remembering her again, only to suffer even more. It's not fair for me to be frustrated right now. I don't have any reason to be frustrated right now."

"...."

"I must know what transpired that evening. I have to see the real deal behind all of this. I must seek the truth, the cause, the beginning, and the way to complete all of this mess at the same time. For my own sake, I must discover what happened to Sera."

“What are you talking about?” Dave seemed to be a bit confused.

"I'm going to the valley. To the basement, where I shared a home with Sera.... To our place.... In order to discover the truth...."

“Hang on for a-”

“Don’t stop me.... I just can’t digest anything going on in my life. I need to seek the truth. There may be a slight chance that I might find something. I want to explore the truth, so don’t stop me. Please let me go. Please tell me where we used to live. Please, doc....”

“Tell him where the place is. I’ll be with him so, he’ll be safe. Please let us go.”

“But can he do it?”

“We’ll face it together. He isn’t alone this time. Trust us, and let us visit his home. Please, doc.”

"Tell me you're going to be fine. Given his condition, it would almost certainly result in something absurd. You're not prepared for that, Maze."

"I don't need to make any preparations. I'm certain we'll figure it out together. Also, this is a one-shot opportunity for our lives to return to normal. We must take this risk. We have to leave, doc. There is no other option."

Dave wasn't overly enthusiastic about the idea in light of the circumstances. However, it was never his choice to make.

"Okay.... Take care of him, though. Never let him get even a few meters away from you. You must be cautious and keep a close eye on him at all times. Do you understand?"

"Of course I will. I'll never let him leave me..."

"Fine.... Take care, both of you."

"Okay, doc."

"Now.... Now.... Jason, it's time for you to rest. I'll have the location ready by tomorrow morning. I'll give it to Maze, and you can leave as soon as tomorrow morning."

"Okay.... Maze, you should take care of our plans and specifically that location, okay?"

"Okay. Don't worry about that. You'll need to rest now."

"Mhmm...."

"I'll get the address from him and get right back to you. You should go ahead and go to sleep. Good night, Jason."

"Okay. Good night."

** *Maze left the room and went to Dave's room* **

"This is the hand-written map of the place. It's been more than six years but this map will somehow be identical to the original one. Okay so, once you cross the valley, you'll come across this junction and all you need to do is take left from this passage. Soon, you'll see a pond, surrounded with dandelions. Then, walk left for a few minutes and you will see a old cottage which leads to the basement. Is this clear?"

"Yes. I'll take of this."

"Also, take these with you. If Jason suffers from any episode, inject this from his left shoulder. This'll help him remember the present. After he regains consciousness, wait for a few minutes and feed him this tablet. Also, take care if you notice even slight changes in his behavior. Watch out for everything possible. Call me if there's something wrong. Do you get it, Maze?"

"Okay. I got it."

"So, take rest now. Tomorrow's going to be really tough."

"Okay. Good night, doc."

** *The next morning* **

The morning began with Jason packing his luggage, Maze preparing both breakfast and lunch for everyone, and Dave reading the newspaper in the garden. It was Dave who felt low about Jason and Maze's plan as they were about to head out. He had been skeptical of this trip the entire time, but now he felt worried after seeing them depart in a dash with no one around to look backwards.

"Everything is in place. Should we go?"

"Okay."

"The engine might trouble you, so get prepared for it."

"Okay, fine. Just hand her the keys."

"Call me if there's any trouble."

"Okay. Don't get too worked up. I'll look after him."

And with that, they left the place to embark on a new journey, eager to uncover the truth within their deepest paths. Now, each of the three pawns has established a specific role.

"Take a left from the museum."

"No, that's not the way. We have to keep going straight."

"Yeah, I'm aware of that. It is a different location. It won't take longer than an hour."

"But where're we heading?"

"To meet someone, someone who's truly **notable**...."

CHAPTER VI

THE RIPPLE EFFECT

*"What prompts an individual to develop **immorality**? The awaiting path in the glint of **darkness**, **malevolent** eyes, and what else awaits them? What is the prime **genesis** behind all of this?"*

Like always, the shrine was filled with the followers and locals, from the entrance to the exit. Every Saturday, the shrine holds a prolonged session, which is celebrated by those in attendance. The *gumba's* ambience was so captivating that it could entice people to escape reality and enter a tranquil, magical world. It was almost time to begin the program, as the monks had already assembled. As soon as the head monk waved his hand to start the session, a young girl in the audience stood up and asked, "Greetings. Today, I have a simple question. Where does an individual's ethics end and their immorality begin?"

The head monk chuckled and stood up from his seat.

"Before we can comprehend the different phases that a human being advances through, we have to learn what ethics and morality entail, depending on the circumstances. Since morality is not innate in any conscious existence, including humans, the tide may shift before the outer world observes it.

A hawk, when it's on the peak of hunting, tears out the throat of some defenseless prey mercilessly. Similarly, an elephant ages until its teeth fall out and it starves to death, painfully and gradually, and the hunters are back in the game, showing no mercy even to their jungle's protector. If you think these are outlandish, the dominant female meerkat in a clan controls breeding and kills the young of those who aren't her own to make sure her very own offspring has the best chance of survival. In between all of this madness occurring, nothing in the universe cares. But how does that compare to the lives of humans? Humans are also animals, except that they have the ability to reflect on themselves and devise moral codes. They chose a specific set of values as an ideal, and while those ideals change, one thing remains constant: people are not born with the ability to fit those ideals. In this regard, asking how someone becomes immoral is analogous to asking how someone becomes bad at playing the piano. People are not born with the ability to play the piano, and those who attempt to do so do so in a haphazard and unpracticed manner. There is an idea of the greatest possible pianist, but such a person does not exist in reality. And most people aren't particularly interested in becoming great pianists. It just doesn't really cross their mind. Though they might listen to a touching piece by an accomplished master and, in that moment, be struck by the beauty of it, they leave the concert thinking about how their work is going. "Where does an individual's ethics end?" Well, the answer is "never." Being immoral doesn't imply that ethics have vanished. Only the devil is completely evil and immoral, not humans.

What prompts an individual to develop immorality? The awaiting path in the glint of darkness, malevolent eyes, and what else awaits them? What is the prime genesis behind all of this? Well, I believe that a person is driven to a void when the ethics he idealized do not work in their favor. That incites someone to act immorally. Even emotions play an important role here. We never know what caused someone to abandon their ideals and walk the dark path. It wouldn't be erroneous to say that without adequate comprehension, we cannot find an answer, and our doubts remain within ourselves. But it's too early to give up. Let me assure you that everything that is broken can be fixed. You simply need to put in more effort to succeed.

So with humans. We may think about our moral ideals, and we may look up to paragons of goodness, but we are not by default good. Not because of some original sin that makes us always fall short of perfection, but simply because those ideals are not the default state of affairs. Instead of debating whether something is morally good or bad, one should strive for positivity at all times, if possible. In conclusion, let me reiterate that there is no such thing as the end of ethics and the beginning of immorality. It is human nature to question our moral ideals."

"Clap.... Clap.... Clap...." Jason praised the head for his insightful counsel. Following his applause, the young girl and the audience joined Jason. The head observed Jason and expressed his happiness at seeing him again. The session continued while he patiently awaited for it to end.

** *An hour later* **

"I told you how wise he is. I'm not sure, but his aura is so divine that it's simply inspiring." Jason expressed his thoughts to Maze.

"Yeah, he's impressive." Maze responded.

"Oh, there he is. Hey! Old man. Hey!" Jason motioned to the head.

"I'll return right away. You may proceed without me." The head informed the council.

"How're you doing, young man?"

"I'm fine. How about you?"

"As appealing as our *Tibetan* tea. Are you here to have a drink with me?"

"I'm afraid not. I don't know; I just wanted to come back to this place. It's as if my mind just led me here."

"Whatever the reason might be, it's good to see you again."

"Yeah...."

"And who is the young lady? Is she your girlfriend?"

"Oh, she's Maze. Maze, he's the leader of the monks' council."

"Hello, sir. Greetings...."

"Greetings. It's not necessary to be so formal, really. I can almost feel your regard."

"It's all my pleasure."

"Anyway, if not the tea, what brings you here?"

"Nothing in particular, but I guess this place is so magical that my heart itself lured me here."

"I'm glad you feel that way. But are you sure that's all there is to it? Is there anything bothering you? You are still as apprehensive as you were previously."

"That's not the case. I'm all right."

“I think we should leave. We still have about five hours to travel."

"Oh okay."

"Are you in a hurry?"

"Yeah, actually, we're going to the valley to visit my old house."

"Is that correct? Are you both?"

“Yes, sir. It’s getting late, so we have to leave.”

“Well then, I wish you both a safe journey. Keep visiting, young man, and bring your lady with you too.”

"Okay, fine. I'll have that tea of yours the next time we meet. I'm hoping it tastes as good as you keep saying it does."

"You'll know that my taste is really stupendous."

"We'll see about that.”

“Have a good day, sir. Take care of yourself.”

“Oh my! How polite. You too.”

“Yes, yes. Good day, old man.”

“Oh my! How unusual.”

“Yeah, whatever.”

"And it's the same day as usual." Shrugging his shoulders, the head made his way back to the shrine.

As Jason and Maze departed with the head monk, the composure turned to be rather gloomy. The trees were moving, and the flags too, while a slight drizzle was about to be expected, showing how Jason and Monsoon, despite their terrible amalgamation, intertwined with each other, sharing a common purpose of bursting into droplets, and revealing a loud roar like those of thunderclaps.

“Let me drive.” Jason said.

“But why? You should take rest.”

“I’m okay. Its just that I feel sleepy, sitting on the passenger seat. Driving will keep me engaged and awake.”

“Is that so? Okay, have it your way.”

“Thanks....”

Jason was in charge of their descent into the valley. Having to drive for more than five hours was a draining task. But it was also the picturesque scenery they saw along the way, among which were a smoothly flowing river, the glistening mountain range, the arresting panorama of clear skies and dense clouds, as well as a garden of azaleas embracing the way to the valley, which rendered their journey less tiresome. They arrived in the valley right before dusk, before they even have a chance to grow weary. The golden horizon then welcomed them and warmed their journey to a glorious finish. Because it was already dark, it would have been difficult to follow the map, so they had to stay in a nearby lodge. Even though it was dark everywhere, the streets were illuminated with pole lamps as they explored the city further. The valley was highly renowned for its flashy fireworks, lively and cultural nightlife, azalea gardens, historical infrastructure, home to the country's original poetry and music society, and, most importantly, it is the lone city in the entire nation without police and industries.

"Don't you want to go exploring in the city? It appears to be a lot of fun out there. We should also have a good time."

"I enjoy exploring, but I'm exhausted right now. You can go ahead without me if you want."

"No, you're right. You must be exhausted from all of that driving. Let's just go somewhere peaceful and quiet. All right, babe?"
"Okay. Let's do it."
"Great. Let's go to the lake, shall we?"
"I'll follow you."
"Then, you better hurry up." Maze began to sprint.
"Hey! Take things slowly.... You will injure yourself. Maze!.... Maze!.... Oh, girl.... She's something else."

** *After they arrived at the lake* **

"Two tickets for the boat, please."
"That would be **50** bucks for an hour, ma'am."
"Great! Let's go, babe."
Maze desired to spend some quality time with Jason, but she also wished to provide him with a feeling of comfort and put aside all of his anxieties. Her only concern was for Jason to be content and at peace.
"I've always wanted to boat with you. Finally, my wish has come true."
"Really?...."
"Yes. If it's to be with you, I'm ready to accompany you wherever you go."
"Why though?"
"Isn't it obvious? Because I want you more than anything else in the world."
Jason asked, "Are you happy?" after a brief pause.
"Huh? Of course, I am. I just told you...."
"I mean, with me. Are you happy with me?"

Maze was the next to take a breather. She grabbed Jason's face and drew him in for a kiss.

"Do you get it now?"

“Huh?...."

"You're such a moron when it comes to understanding. I'm glad to have you, of course. I am filled with such optimism, hope, and enthusiasm because you stepped into my life and changed everything for me. Since the moment I fell in love with you, I’ve set everything aside for you. I have no idea what's good or bad for me, what the advantages and disadvantages are, or what the hell is. The only thing I see is you and me together for the rest of our lives. My happiness stems mostly from the fact that all I want is you. You are my inspiration, my entire universe, and my sweetest baby. So, never ask me such nonsense again.”

"Mhmm...."

"I really mean it. You don't want me to be ferocious with you. Don't you dare try asking me that question again, Jason Willholm. Do you understand?"

"Yes.... Loud and clear."

"Perfect...."

"Wow! You're scary sometimes."

"Take care not to incite my rage once more."

"Got it.”

“I am hungry. Let’s have something spicy.”

“Sure.”

"Let's get to the hotel as soon as possible. I'm really exhausted right now. Carry me, babe."

"All right, fine. Don't just dive right onto me like that.

"Let's go."

** *The next day* **

“You okay? What happened?”
“Nothing.... I know the truth. I think I’m fine now.”

** *A few minutes before Jason entered the basement* **

“This is it. The junction right after we cross the valley.... This has to be it.”
“Babe, look. There’s a passage at the left.”
“Yeah! Let’s go.”
The wide-ranging vista of the location exuded a noxious and dismal atmosphere throughout. The quietness was as if it were the doorway to something far more sinister and horrendous that was approaching them. The passage was covered in deep slush, making it challenging for them to drive. Something unsettling about this location was inexplicably suggested by all of these things.
"I think we should walk from here." Maze informed Jason.
"Fine."
When they finally spotted the cottage in front of them, they were forced to battle the fury of stormy snow and pass through a frozen pond dotted with dandelions. For a while, there was total stillness. Mostly, Jason was taken aback by what he saw in front of him.
"That door...."
"What about it? Are you all right? Even in this extreme cold, you are perspiring excessively.
"That's the exact same door from my dreams...."

"That door?" Maze uttered it in a terrifying whisper.

"That's it."

Both of them were too scared to react at the time. Jason, who had suffered the most, was frightened. He reasoned in his head that this might be his sole opportunity to seek the truth, but he needed confidence to get past that door.

"Listen, Maze."

"What is it?"

"Stay here and wait for me."

"What? What exactly are you saying?"

"Whatever happens, do not enter the basement. I'll go on my own."

"Are you crazy? No, I can't leave you like this. It can be dangerous....”

"This is my fight, Maze. This is my battle. I'm the only one who has a reason to go inside, not you. You've already done a lot for me, so I'll take it from here. You don't have to suffer any longer for me. You must understand that I must confront this on my own. I’ll do this by myself, so please wait for me."

"But...."

"Trust me; I'll make it back to you. This was my home and my past, and it's all gone now. You believe that I am your home and your future, which is undoubtedly a major reason for me to return safely. Maze, have faith in me. Please wait for me here."

Maze was speechless and emotionally drained by Jason's past. She had not expected him to take such a risk, and she felt a twinge of guilt.

"Please get back to me as soon as possible. I love you."

"I love you, too."

Finally, she let Jason go ahead while she patiently waited for him in the freezing cold.

Jason sensed a strange sensation in the atmosphere. He believed that his nervousness had something to do with his attempts to get in.

"I've got this. Here I come. Back home...."

Jason finally opened the door and walked into the cottage. First, he passed through the hall. Just like the years when he and Sera used to reside there, it was minuscule and very empty. Jason's long-awaited moment had arrived. He eventually came to a halt in front of the basement door.

"Wait! Isn't this the same door as the main entrance? Are they identical? Who cares?...."

His quest for the truth was almost upon him. At last, he opened the door and saw what was truly there.

"...."

“Wait...."

** *A few minutes later* **

"It's so cold. I'm curious if he's warm on the inside. What's taking him so long? Is he okay? Should I go check on him? Oh god...." Maze was about to begin panicking when Jason interrupted her. It was Jason emerging from the entrance to the cottage.

"Come on, let's go. We're done here."

"What? Wait a minute..."

"Let's go...."

"Babe! Wait. Are you okay? What happened?"

“Nothing.... I know the truth. I think I’m fine now."

"Don't you think it's important to tell me?"

"What do you mean?"

"What happened inside? What did you notice? Did you come across anything?"

“Ahh.... about that...."

"Come on, hurry up. Tell me...."

"Well, I saw nothing. It was empty."

"What was empty?"

"The hallway and the basement.... there is absolutely nothing."

"What? That doesn't make any sense.”

“Yeah!”

“But what were you doing there for so long?”

“I was thinking....”

“Thinking?.... What’s there to think? You said it’s empty.”

"I was wondering.... why the door kept showing up in my recurring nightmares. I was wondering.... who was calling my name in the nightmares, urging me to seek the truth as well as additional matters? It was extremely perplexing for me. But now I am feeling like I understand why everything was the way it was supposed to be.”

"What do you know?”

"There was no answer from the beginning. There was no truth to be sought.”

"What?...."

"Yes.... I believe it was Sera's voice beckoning me to meet her at our house. From the moment I was inside, everything seemed to be heading back to how it was when I was a kid.

Once I got in, I recalled everything regarding the past, and I feel much better now. I believe that this cottage, as well as Sera, wanted me to bid them a proper farewell. We created a lot of memories here, so I believe that's the only reason I find it helpful in my situation."

"Is that all? Well, but I am so confused by all of this. Like is it that simple? I don't get it...."

"There's no need for you to worry. I discovered the explanation for all of this, and it was as simple as that. I'm feeling much better now. I'd had this fear for a few days, and seeing that door right in front of me terrified me. That haunting image of something ominous was terrifying to me. I used to carry all of this around with me, but not anymore. When I realized all of this, my heart felt calmer and lighter. I'm in a good mood right now. My fear has disappeared. I'm relieved that I won't have to endure such anguish any longer. I'm so glad."

"Really? Was it successful?

"Yes. Right now, I'm ecstatic. Finally, I know the truth. I did it, Maze. We did it, Maze. We did it...."

"Yes, we did. I am so happy for you, babe."

"Thank you for being with me for all this time."

"You're most welcome."

"Yeah!"

"Oh!.... It's extremely cold. I almost forgot about the weather when I saw you smiling."

"I believe we should leave. Who knows, maybe it will snow even more."

"Yeah, let's go."

"Mhmm...."

And that's all there is to it. That's how the story wraps up. Jason discovered the truth he sought, Maze got a happy and satisfied Jason as her lover, and Dave was happy for both of them, knowing that they're pleased together and everything is back to normal again. Despite all those hurdles, they are now embarking on a new journey that is packed with joy and anticipation. Everything worked out in the end.

Isn't it amusing that whatever appears persuasive actually represents reality or truth? People will accept anything that is convincing enough for them. That is, if the narrator has the ability to captivate the audience's brains. Advice to heed: the truth can be the most absurd lie.

There was an odd sensation in the breeze as Jason and Maze left the scene.

"What are you looking at, babe?" Maze inquired as to why Jason was peering behind the junction.

"Nothing.... We're getting closer...."

CHAPTER VII

THE MALEVOLENT INCEPTION

*"**Dreq**, listen, I've always wanted you to grow up to be a **good** son who has the same aspirations as me, but you've turned into the **devil**."*

"Wake up.... It's almost time to get up.... Dreq!.... Dreq!...." An unknown person yelled at Dreq.

"Dreq!.... Dreq!...."

"**DREQ!**" Dreq got up to hear a man's deep voice.

"Wake up, son."

"Good morning, **father**. I'd been expecting you all along. You're ten minutes late today."

"Is that so? Now, get ready for today's session. Your brothers are expecting you."

"Okay, father. As you wish."

Every day was the same for Dreq. His father used to wake him up as usual, then he would get ready and rush to the hall, forming a queue with his brother for the session. Actually, the session was....

"**A GOVERNMENT PROJECT TO TRAIN CHILDREN FOR THE WAR?....** I thought it was just a rumor, but such a move from them surprised me. This has to be the most revolutionary moment in history." The news was relayed to a psychiatric ward nurse.

"Yes, this news is going to shake the entire world...." The second nurse boasted.

“Hey, you two! What are you two up to? Get back to work...." Sera yelled at them.

"Let's go!"

“An army of powerful children?.... That's absurd."

"Yes. It must be difficult for Miss Willholm to manage such a force."

"Yes. I feel terrible for her now..."

"But what exactly is a special ward?"...."

"No one knows....."

The Special Ward was a remote enclave outside of the regular hierarchy, controlled by Sir **Albert Dowski**, the Commander in Chief of the military, recognized for his excellent choices and authority. The primary objective of the outpost was to build young soldiers with superhuman strength for service in the military. A few years ago, the nation was under attack by an alliance of eleven nations, including their neighboring nation. As a result, the armed forces were outnumbered in both soldiers and weapons. It was unfortunate that they were defeated. Thus, for the past two years in a row, the government has been experimenting on young children with the goal of strengthening the military's status and utilizing them as lethal weapons of mass destruction. This has been the nation's most challenging mission, and only a few high-ranking officers, doctors, and scientists were aware of it. Furthermore, given that Sera Willholm supervised the children's psychiatric ward, it was apparent that she was aware of this. However, she was not fully informed of the government's activities.

** *Children at the Special Ward* **

"Good morning, my sons," welcomed Albert Dowski.

"Good morning, father," greeted the children.

"How're you all? Did you get enough sleep?"

"Yes, father."

"Very well. So, today is Friday, and do you know what we do every Friday?"

"Yes, father."

"It's time for a story. Are you ready, my sons?"

"Yes, father."

"Yes, father!" shouted Dreq.

"Okay, I hear all of you loud and clear. Let's begin."

"Once upon a time, there were two brothers. **Derzelas** and **Djall** were the two individuals. Derzelas was a **hardworking** and **courageous** man who dedicated his entire life to creating an **elixir** that could extend anyone's lifespan by over twenty years and thus worked extremely hard on it for months and days. Meanwhile, Djall was a **brave** and **powerful** man who was well-known for his strength among the youth.

One day, Derzelas was working on his elixir when he was interrupted by Djall. Djall was aware of his elder brother's work. When Djall inquired about the elixir, Derzelas yelled at him and threw him out of his workshop. Djall was furious about it. After a few days, he discovered that the potion could extend someone's lifespan by over twenty years. So he decided to drink the elixir in order to take revenge on his brother. When Derzelas finished preparing the elixir, Djall interrupted him again and attempted to steal the potion.

Djall easily defeated his brother and acquired control of the elixir thanks to his physical prowess. He desired his brother's attention after obtaining the elixir. He drank the elixir as a result to prove that he's also capable like him. Before long, he was making fun of his brother and enjoying his longer life. However, after a few minutes, Djall abruptly stopped celebrating. He went numb for a while. Gradually, he became aware of his body's rising temperature and aching muscles. Then he inquired, "What did you mix into the elixir?" "That's not the elixir. It's a poison," his brother replied. Djall was astonished by what he said and felt discomfort, but he still questioned, "Why did you do that to me? I was simply attempting to demonstrate to you that I am as capable and intelligent as you are. Why?" Derzelas remained silent as he watched his evil brother die in front of him."

"And this tale teaches us that good and hardworking people always succeed in life. Did you get it, my sons?"

"Yes, father."

"Very well.... Now we'll..."

"Father!" Dreq raised his hand to question him.

"Yes, my son."

"How come Djall is the only evil character, but Derzelas isn't? Djall only wanted to exact a minor retaliation in exchange for his brother's approval. But, on the other hand, Djall murdered his own brother without mercy? Also, Derzelas was smarter and older than Djall, but he chose not to sort things out. That must imply that Derzelas is more **evil** than Djall. Aren't I correct, father?"

Dreq's inquiry piqued the interest of the others as well.

"Slap!.... That is why you must not disobey me. You should never speak to your father in that tone. Is that understood?" Exasperated, Albert gave Dreq a slap.

“Yes, father. I'll never disobey you again."

"That's my son. Be careful for the next time. I don’t want to punish you at all.”

“Yes, father. I’ll never repeat my mistakes.”

“Well, you may now leave.”

“Yes, father.”

Dreq was perplexed, trying to figure out where he'd gone wrong. He wondered if he was disobeying his father or if he was reacting to someone else's rage. And, yet again, Dreq was concerned about his relationship with Albert. He believed that disagreeing with his father was a sign that he had turned into a bad son to him. Hence, to be a good son, he sought approval from his father and never complained about anything ever again. It didn't take long for him to believe that Djall was actually evil and Derzelas was good.

While the government conducted experiments on children in order to reinforce the superhuman force in the military for about a month or two, the present military was impoverished by the alliance. The nation's armed forces had been struck with unpredictable wars like a disease, and the commander in chief, Albert Dowski, appeared to be the most annoyed person on the assignment.

"The north outpost suffered a tremendous loss of **102** soldiers, and the two outposts surrounding the main one lost a total of **48** soldiers. This information is a huge blow to us." An officer informed Albert about the consequences of the war.

"How many men were there?" Albert inquired.

"A total of **248** soldiers of enemy. **102** in the north outpost and **48** in two outposts were killed by them."

"That many died?"

"I'm afraid, yes."

"Immediately convene an emergency meeting. I'll report to the special ward in an hour. Call every man within a **45**-kilometer radius of the ward. This is an urgent issue that must be addressed immediately."

"Right, sir."

Albert was enraged with the situation he had been accountable for, and the officer hurriedly left the chief's house to inform the message.

"I'm leaving," Albert became enraged and yelled.

"When?" Dave was curious.

"Today."

"Is that such an important thing?"

"Yes, I might not be home for a while, so take care of my kids." Albert declared.

"But where're you heading?"

"To commence the greatest war humanity has ever witnessed...."

Albert's bold declaration baffled Dave, and his eyes were scarred, as if he had met death in front of him. Dave was aware that his brother could risk everything to demonstrate his commitment to his responsibilities. His image as the chief was his sole source of pride. He was concerned that the world might witness terror. The chief's rage was a sign of an impending ablaze that would cause a bloodstream of bodies as well as the flames across the globe.

"Do you mean two weeks? That's ridiculous." Albert faced an inquiry by a scientist in the audience.

"Yes. That's what I said. Everyone, you have heard correctly." Albert declared.

"But that's not enough. We need at least a month to guarantee you an army."

"Tell me, how many children do we have?"

"A total of **940** children, sir."

"And you, please tell me, what percentage of this group succeeds?" Albert confronted the scientist.

"With a little optimism, I predict that **60**% of them will survive."

"That would be more than enough for us. Begin the experiments right away. That is an order."

“Are you joking? This is a serious matter. What do-“

"Do you think I'm joking? Do these eyes seem like they belonged to a clown? I'm dead serious. Do you get what I'm saying, doctor?" Albert seized the scientist's neck and choked him until he agreed to his plan.

“Argh!.... Yes.... Arghh!.... Yes, sir....” Albert freed the scientist.

"Does everyone in this room understand what I said?"

"Yes, sir." The entire room screamed.

"Let them in starting tomorrow. It makes no difference how you scientists go about your work. But all that matters is that I need those kids as weapons of mass destruction within the next two weeks. I want that **60**% success rate to be accurate. You will suffer the consequences if you don't do it. Is that understood?"

"Yes, sir.” They agreed the order and left the room.

When everyone had left the room, it was just Albert all by himself. Albert suddenly burst out laughing in a loud and terrifying manner.

"Haha.... Haha.... *evil laugh* The world will know who Sir Albert Dowski is. The world will know what it's like to experience true defeat. Soon, every one of the eleven nations is going to experience destruction. I will exterminate them all with my own hands. I will destroy their entire military and everything they have to offer. They started this war, and I'm the one who will put an end to it. I'm going to annihilate everything. Hahaha! Everything...."

—

"Why does it rain?" muttered Dreq as he stared out the window at the sky.

“Well, because it’s the time of the monsoon. During this season, we experience rainy days and nights.” Sera replied.

“....”

“Don’t you like when it rains?”

“No, I don’t.”

“Why so?”

“It makes me sad.”

“Why? What happened?”

“It irritates me when it rains. The droplets of rain, always striking together at the same spot, remind me of how lonely and confined my life is.”

"Who said you're lonely? Take a look around you. They're all your brothers and sisters. This is where you live. This is your home. We are always available to assist you. You must know who your family is by now, don't you?"

"Yes, exactly. You’re correct.”

"My father is my family, and so are they. But I adore my father more than they do, or anyone else."

"Ahh!.... That's one reason you shouldn't be lonely. Prepare to go to the hall now. Come on, hurry up." Sera wasn't pleased with him because he had no idea who his father really was.

"Okay, fine.""Okay, fine."

"Father? What a horrible way to reconcile your horrible deeds with family matters." Sera, with her finger on her forehead, was concerned about the children. Inside, she despised Albert Dowski more than anyone else. In addition, she felt as though she were suffocating while working under him like a pig, spending a whole day on the farm before it was slaughtered. It was extremely difficult for her to live in his shadow every day.

Days passed, and everything was proceeding according to Albert's plan. Almost half of those involved have already been given the medications and tonics needed to boost their normal strength to levels that are unparalleled.

"If we complete the entire process within 10–12 days, it'll only take a few hours for the superhuman serum to react."

"Great! We're talking now." Albert was astounded to hear such wonderful news.

"I must admit, Chief, that you are a ruthless man. I mean, you don't really care about those children, do you?" While Albert was observing the tests, an officer approached him.

"Be mindful of your tone. I don't care whether you live or die. Do you want special treatment from me? Huh?"

"No, sir. I apologize for my inappropriate behavior."

"It's not that I'm not interested in them. I mean, according to their amateurism and kind heart, I'm still their father, who has been raising them since their parents abandoned them. However, I chose to focus on the big picture. Their deaths and sacrifices will not be in vain. It'll be a sacrifice for the nation, and the whole world will be proud of-"

** *An emergency alert activates* **

"Hey, you. What's the matter?" The officer inquired about a doctor who had just appeared in front of him.

"The Special Ward, where the children who had just received the dose are kept, is being attacked.... by the children themselves...."

"What the...."

"Come on, everyone. Everyone, drop everything you're doing and head straight to the Special Ward right away. Immediately.... Now...." Albert had gone insane after hearing such harrowing news.

In the meantime, as everyone was preoccupied with watching the experiment, children began killing the security guards and the officers. All of the children who had attained superhuman abilities began murdering officers and doctors, destroying buildings and outposts nearby, and going on a rampage.

"What is going on?" Albert was perplexed to see what was in front of him. He saw children destroy the ward, buildings, weapons, vehicles, and nearly everything in their path.

"Inform everyone present that they must immediately report to the Special Ward. I'm going to repeat it again. Inform every officer present today that they must report to the Special Ward immediately." Albert screamed angrily into the walkie-talkie, pleading for assistance from every armed officer on the scene."Hello, this is the captain of the second squad reporting. Sir, we've run out of men. Over 200 soldiers had been killed within a **45**-kilometer radius. We're now down to about **100** men. I repeat. We're now down to **100** men."Fuck!.... Fuck!.... Why the hell is this happening to me?" Albert screamed irritably.

"Fuck! How could this have happened to me?" Albert pulled his gun from his coat pocket and prepared to take serious action. He walked quietly through the hallway, towards the center hall, where the children were wreaking havoc. Whoever he came across in his path, he didn't hesitate to shoot every suspicious individual in front of him. After walking through the corridor, he arrived at the central hall, where he saw a few children destroying the place."What exactly is going on?" Albert fired a shot into the air in order to draw attention.

"Father! I'm relieved that you're safe. I was so concerned that-" Albert fired at the boy who was approaching him. There was complete silence at that moment. The children became numb after witnessing the cruel death of their brother at the hands of their beloved father.

"Father?.... I don't get it.... Why did you-..." Albert fired at another child without any additional thought. Then, a girl standing near the dead body started to weep, only to be shot by him.

** *Meanwhile, in the psychiatric ward* **

"Everyone, hurry up. We must flee as soon as possible...." Sera was assisting the remaining children in fleeing.

"SHOOT AT THE SCENE! SHOOT THE CHILDREN IF YOU SEE THEM! IT'S A DIRECT ORDER. KILL THOSE CHILDREN!" This decision from the government shocked everyone.

Following the experiment's failure, government officials feared that the children would wipe out the entire military, causing a massive loss to the nation as a whole. To prevent this from happening, they announced that they were going to massacre all the children and blaze the ward with them.

"Come on, hurry up. Everyone must pass through this door. Faster, faster...."

"Here! Here! Run as fast as you can...."

"Hey! What're you doing?" Sera asked Dreq.

"Helping father." Dreq responded.

"What? Do you mean Albert?"

"Yes. This is his plan."

"What? I'm confused."

"Clear my doubts, will you?"

"I don't know everything, but I know that our father does not want us to lose our lives while battling against the bad guys in the war. As a result, I am helping him. This is all part of his plan. I'm going to do everything I can to help this plan succeed. This will make my father extremely proud of me." While putting in a lot of effort to flee his brothers and sisters, Dreq was pleased and very close to making his father proud.

"Listen to me. That's rubbish."

"What's rubbish about it?"

"Whoever said that to you is lying."

"What? No way...."

"Yes, it is."

"How're you so sure about it?"

"Because I know who you're talking about. Whatever you said is utter rubbish. But first, tell me who told you all of this nonsense-"

"**DREQ!....**" Albert appeared on the scene, drenched in blood all over his uniform, and yelled at Dreq.

"Father. I'm relieved you're safe. But what happened to your coat? Whose blood-"

"**SHUT UP!....**" Albert landed an intense kick on Dreq's ribs.

"Hey! He's only a kid-"

"**DON'T GET IN MY WAY, BITCH!....**" Albert shoved Sera through the door and up the stairs.

Albert's gaze shifted towards Dreq as Sera was laying unconscious on the concrete surface.

"Father? What's the matter?"

He stood still for a while, scratching his own face with his hands and wiping away the blood from his eyes. He now approached the injured Dreq with his threatening eyes.

"What's the matter, father? What happened to you-" Albert smacked him across the face.

"What's the matter? Seriously? Huh? *Kicks Dreq* What's the matter, you ask? *Continues to kick* What were you thinking? Huh? What drove you to do this? *Continues to kick* Dreq, answer me. Why? Why?"

"Father?" Dreq was baffled and curious as to what he had done wrong.

"Everything has been destroyed because of you. Everything!.... *Kicks again* Tell me why you used them to destroy everything. Why did you employ them to thwart my plans? Why? What's the reason for this? *Kicks again* Tell me, you little piece of shit. Tell me! *Kicks again* Tell me. Tell me, Dreq. Tell me-“ His ankle was broken as a result of the altercation with the other children and the kick Albert gave to Dreq. He was helpless there.

"Argh!.... Fuck!...." Albert tripped and fell to the ground.

"Father? Are you all right, Father? Where does it hurt? Father, please tell me. "Please tell me-“

"**SHUT THE FUCK UP!....**" Another time, Albert's blow left a huge scar on Dreq's face, with blood streaming through his face.

"Why did you do this to me? Huh? Why, Dreq?"

"Father. Please explain what's wrong. I don't understand what you're saying."

"I'm disappointed in you, Dreq," Albert said.

"Huh?...." Dreq's eyes began to well up with tears.

"Dreq, listen, I've always wanted you to grow up to be a good son who has the same aspirations as me, but you've turned into the devil."

"**Huh**?...." Dreq was rendered speechless.

"In fact, you share my ambitions. You and I have something in common. I am a ruthless man, and you have proven to be quite evil. The treacherous son who betrayed his father. Yes, Dreq, you are evil. You truly are evil. You truly are."

Yes, you are evil, Dreq. You truly are evil... You're evil, Dreq. You truly are.... Evil.... Truly.... Evil.... TRULY EVIL! Albert's words were crammed into Dreq's mind. For a while, he felt numb.

"However, I must say. You were excellent at being evil. You played me very well. You were a genius. Wow. *Claps*"

"This personality suits you. You should be a **villain**. You should continue being evil. Please proceed to be **evil** and destroy everything like you did today."

"Fuck!.... Fuck you, Dreq." With that said, Albert knocked Dreq out with a final blow across his face.

"Argh! Fuck! *Albert Punched Dreq....*"

—

The emphasis is now on the present. Dreq was knocked out, and the last thing he saw was Albert's fist approaching his face. The narrative returns back to the present, with Jason's eyes anchored on the current situation. (Jason opens his eyes.)

—

"Jason! Jason! Jason!" Maze called out Jason's name after noticing him staring at the portrait in the party palace's hallway.

"Huh? Yes?" Jason realized Maze had called him.

"What were you thinking when you were staring at the painting? You felt as if you were lost in your own world."

"I appreciated the portrait. It felt nostalgic to me, so I couldn't help but stare at it."

"What's so special about this painting? It's merely a knife toppling over an apple."

"That's the portrait's forte. You won't get it."

"Are you making fun of me? You've been so mean since we got back."

"It's me when I'm normal. You tell me if you're comfortable with this version of myself."

"Sure, whatever. Now, let's get going so we don't miss the party."

"Yes, let's blaze the soirée."

It's been two weeks since Jason and Maze came back from the valley. Jason had been free of hallucinations and any kind of recurring vision since then. And today marks the 50th anniversary of the hospital where Dave used to work. Thus, all three of them are here for the ceremony. For the time being, everything appears to be returning to normal.

"Well, don't you look gorgeous, Maze? This black gown looks great on you." Dave thought highly of Maze's attire.

"Thank you. You look great in this coat, too."

"Well, thank you, dear. And as for Jason, I'm at a loss for words. You're glistening like a newlywed groom." Dave showed his appreciation for Jason in a hilarious way.

"I'm sure you'll be speechless." Jason chuckled softly, making direct eye contact with Dave.

"Have you guys had anything to eat or drink?"

"No, we just got here."

"All right, then, have fun. I recommend that you have a special wine, one of the most rare wines in the world, specially ordered from the West for today's occasion. You'll enjoy it as well, Jason."

"Is that so? Let's have a look, shall we?"

"Yes, let's go."

"Tell me how it is, okay? Haha!"

“Sure. Let's go, Jason."

It is past time, ladies and gentlemen, that we elevate this function to a higher level. Now, we'd like to introduce you to the nation's most popular classical music band. Please give a standing ovation to none other than The Dreamers Choir."

Everyone in the audience began to applaud.

"Please enjoy a full hour of musical excellence played without interruption.”

** *The performers began playing their piece* **

"The decorations are commendable, to be sure. I can't take my eyes off those portraits across the stairwells and corridors. They're simply breathtaking-" Dave became aware that someone was constantly staring at him.

"Dave, the wine is wonderful too, isn't it?"

"Ahh! Of course, yes. Please excuse me for a moment." Dave pursued the unidentified man in a face mask.

"Hello? Please excuse me, sir! Hello, sir." Dave attempted to converse with the man, but he completely ignored him and continued walking.

"Please excuse me, sir. Sir!...." Dave followed the man all the way to the restroom.

"Where'd he go?" Even though Dave was moving quite rapidly for his age, he found himself incapable of keeping up with the stranger's pace as he followed him all the way across the way to the restroom, which had barely any light.

"Who was that guy? And where has he gone?"

** A whistling sound approached Dave **

"Who's that?" Dave inquired nervously as the whistling man approached him.

"What do you want from me? Who are you?" The sound of the whistle and the man became even closer.

"Don't you hear me?" The distance was close enough that Dave finally caught sight of the man's face, which was unanticipated.

"You?...." The man ceased his whistling.

"What's the matter with you? You scared me."

The man pulled a lighter from his pocket and lit the cigarette that was already in his mouth.

"Answer me. What is all of this, Jason?"

"Shhhhhh!...." Dave shuddered when he noticed his voice connected with the smoke.

"Since when did you start smoking?"

"...."

"What's wrong with you? Can't you hear me?"

"...."

"I'm talking to you. Don't ignore me like this, Jason-"

"Shhhhhh!...." He gave Dave a fistful of slaps across his face.

"Be quiet. I haven't allowed you to speak...."

"Argh! That hurts."

"*Whistles again*"

"Why did you hit me, Jason-"

"SHUT THE FUCK UP!" Dave was smacked a second time.

"Argh!" In pain, Dave let out a scream.

"Don't get too worked up. It pales in comparison to the agony you inflicted on me."

"What're you talking about?"

"Come on, don't act like that around me. The girl isn't listening to us. Don't act."

"...." Dave locked his gaze on Jason.

"...." Jason kept staring as well.

“The note? The Special Ward? The one who led the children. Remember?”

“What?”

“Do you remember me now?”

“**DREQ?**”

“**BINGO!**”

** *Back to the past* **

"When I woke up following that traumatic event at the ward, the sole thing I remembered was seeing myself covered in bandages. I could hardly open my eyes, and my entire body felt so sluggish that I couldn't move a single finger. My ribs were fractured, and my upper body was severely burned as a result of the ward fire. The government decided to burn the entire building down while everyone inside was still alive, and they succeeded. Except for me, everyone I knew was either dead or close to death. That didn't bother me in the least. Actually, I had no recollection of what had occurred then. I tried so hard to remember, but I couldn't recall anything. And after a few days, I eventually stopped trying.

Sera was the one who saved my life. She and I both escaped from the ward, which resulted in her being listed on a wanted poster. She was given the order to shoot immediately, and, there was a monetary reward pinned to her head. Because she had chosen to live that way, she took me with her, and so, we spent our lives concealed inside of a tiny cottage far from everyone. I had no memories of my past even after my recovery. Furthermore, she never let me recall anything, mostly the terrible ones. Everything she did to me during those years was commendable. I'll never forget her. She will live on in my memories, and I will always-“

"Did you kill her? Answer me-" Dreq broke Dave’s mouth.

"Don't interrupt me when I’m talking."

"Argh! Argh!" In agony, Dave screamed.

"No one will hear you. I suppose the music is too loud."

"Argh!" Dave screamed more and more.

"All right, back to your question. Yes, indeed. Unfortunately, she died at my hands. After everything she did to me, I regret killing her. But who can blame me? I was only 16 or 17 at that time."

"Yoooouuu-"

"What? I don't understand what you're saying. First, clean the blood.”

“**Eeeevvvviiiillllll.... EVIL!....**”

"The night before you read her note was her final night. It was extremely upsetting for me. Oh sorry! That was my oversight. It was extremely upsetting for Jason.... Take a look at your eyes. What would you like to say?"

"Yoooouuu-"

"I was having trouble remembering, and my head felt so heavy that I didn't bother talking to her. You guys were looking for me while I left for a few minutes. After I reached the cottage, she continued to inquire about my well-being and started panicking. Blah! Blah!..... I eventually snapped and screamed at her."

"**SHUT UP**!" Dreq yelled at Sera.

"Shit! Sera, I didn't mean to yell at you. It's only-"

"**You're just like him.**" Sera replied after a long pause.

"**Huh?....**" Dreq stared at Sera.

"**You're just like that trash, Albert!**"

"**Huh?....**" Dreq was triggered.

"**After all I did for you, after all the hell I endured for you, this is how you treat me. Undoubtedly, you're like Albert.**"

"**Sera.... Please stop it.**"

"**Your so-called idiot father was exactly the same. Actually, you are similar because you believe he is your biological father. Father? My foot, father!**"

"**Stop it....**"

"**He was a scumbag who always took advantage of people. He had no regard for anyone but himself. He was the worst.**"

"**And now you're becoming more like him. The identical tone, the exact same body posture, those menacing blue eyes—I thought you'd changed. Even though I assumed you were content with me, don't you just want to resemble him? I'm so relieved he's not here anymore. Otherwise, it would have been hell for me. I'm relieved that he's dead-**"

** *Dreq hurled a sharp pocket knife at Sera, striking her in the throat* **

"Stop it," Dreq shrieked in a raged whisper.

Sera collapsed to the floor and died instantly after the knife pierced her throat.

"...." Dreq stood for a moment in silence.

"**DON'T DISRESPECT MY FATHER!**"

"I still regret killing her. She took such good care of me. She must have felt betrayed by me in the end. She must have assumed I was evil."

"...." Dave kept staring at Dreq with bewildered eyes.

"I understand what you're thinking. If I'm Dreq from the Special Ward, who the hell is Jason? Well, you'd understand better because you're an expert in this."

** *Back to the past* **

After I wrote you a note, I went back to her body and experienced the most disturbing thing I had ever experienced in my entire life.

"**No! No! No! No! NOOO!**" Dreq screamed in pain.

"**SERA!....**" Dreq began to sob and scream in agony..

"**SERA! Sera, please wake up. Please get up. Don't leave me alone. Sera, please. Please....**"

Then, the body rushed out of the cottage, yelling, "**Help! Help! Someone, please help!**"

I was puzzled to witness what was going on. It was as if my body was reacting on its own.

"**HELP! HELP!**" My body was out of my control.

"**HELP! PLEASE HELP ME!**"

However, nobody was around to hear.

You might be perplexed at this point. Who yelled? Who wept for her? It was, of course, **JASON**.

He was my **alter ego**. That's what I referred to him as. The body was one, and I'm not sure about the soul, but there were two different people living at the same time."

"I was also completely perplexed. I had no idea what had happened, but my body was not mine. I was unable to regulate my own body. I was limited to observing what my body did. I was able to switch bodies with him once, but it only lasted a few seconds before I was trapped inside my own body again. It was the worst time of my life."

"...." Dave lay on the floor, utterly defenseless, staring at Dreq.

"But one day, everything changed when I noticed something strange. A few days later, while he had complete control over my body, he was wandering around the streets with no idea where he was going. He had a pitiful personality and no sense. Then I heard a truck coming up behind us. Because it was dark that night, the driver did not see us. But I heard everything, and I assumed he heard the truck as well. As a result, I assumed he would move out of the way. He, however, did not.

"Hey, you! You moron! Don't you hear the truck coming up behind you? Move or we'll both die."

"...." He was walking constantly.

"Move, you moron. Save the body...."

And suddenly, he saw the truck and moved away from the road.

“That was close. What’s wrong with him? Doesn’t he have any common sense? Shall I test my theory?”

“Hey, you. Say my name aloud. Say **DREQ**.”

“**DREQ**!” The body screamed.

“**BINGO**!”

“That’s magnificent....”

“**And I realized Jason was a puppet, and I was his puppeteer. I've been manipulating Jason through our mind ever since. I paved the path from the point where I fell in front of you to the point where we returned to the valley. I even named him after a dog from the special ward who was simply controlled by the military, as I controlled Jason. I was responsible for everything. And it was a success. This is my achievement. I'm finally back. It feels great to be back. Haha!....**"

"...." The man before him filled Dave with fear. He saw a glimpse of an invincible demon in Dreq's shadow, and no one could defeat him.

"**I know you had a hunch, but it was something you might not have imagined. I manipulated Jason into forgetting everything because my plans were flawed at the time. I repeated it several times, and then you said that Jason forgets everything when he sleeps, so don't let him sleep. Haha! You walked right into my traps. I don't blame you for it. Even the most astute minds could not fathom such madness. And now I've done it. I've finally made it back. I've regained control of my own body. I have conquered this enigma.**”

"Is your **alter ego** gone for good?...." Dave inquired.

“Ahh!.... About that....”

** *What actually happened inside the basement* **

His quest for the truth was almost upon him. At last, he opened the door and saw what was truly there.

"...."

“Wait....”

—

“....?” Jason discovered something but couldn't see what it was because of the darkness. As Jason approached the scene, he encountered the most horrifying experience of his life.

“Th-“ Jason discovered a long-decomposed corpse covered in bugs and resembling a skeleton. It was pure hell for him. His perception of the scene caused him to lose consciousness and collapse on the ground.

"...." Jason passed out.

—

"...." After a few seconds, Dreq awoke and stood. Then he took a lighter from his inner pocket and lit his cigarette.

He sat next to Sera's decomposed corpse.

"With that, your son is gone. He'll join you soon. Rest in peace, Sera. Rest in peace, Jason. And now please leave me alone.... HAHAHA!...."

Because of Dreq's manipulation, Jason came to realize that it was Sera's body, but it was already late. He then stood in front of a bridge of agony. That moment destroyed him completely, and the pressure forced him to jump off the bridge. He plummeted into the void. Jason will never be able to escape the void. He was extinguished from all of existence. That night, he truly **died**.

That evening, Dreq made a comeback and hauled Dave with him into a harsh future.

"**And a final question for you. What is the reason behind my death?**" Dave was barely upright, and his back was against the building's walls.

"We're at the point of peak intensity, aren't we?"

"I hope so."

"Do you remember the date today?"

"Ahh! Yes, I do."

"Perfect! Let's travel back **14** years. Are you experiencing something?"

"Huh...." Dave abruptly recognized the reason for his impending death.

"How do you feel?"

"So, this is how it ends?...."

"Shall we do a quick recap? Tell me everything from beginning to end, and try not to leave anything out...."

** *Fourteen years ago* **

Dave knew exactly how cruel and vindictive Albert could be. He was well aware that his brother would go to any length for his own pride. He was a ruthless man who exploited others for his own gain. So Dave decided to end it for the better. Therefore, Dave created a fake note in which he pretended to be Albert. He wrote that the government is forcing him to experiment on children as war sacrifices, and that his life is in danger. He knew the children were too young to fully comprehend, so he devised an idea to persuade them to oppose Albert's plans.

"Where's Albert?" Dave confronted the officers stationed outside the Special Ward.

"Good day, Dr. Dowski. I believe he is inside the special ward, observing the children."

"All right. He called me right away, so should I go inside?"

"Yes, of course, sir."

"Thank you."

Dave deceived the officers and gained access to the ward. Then he decided to place the note somewhere near the children's grasp so they could read it. He was able to find a spot that was eye-catching. The kids who were ready for the test were kept in a separate room. So Dave threw that note through the window, hoping that someone would read it and respond quickly. And his plans had begun to bear fruit, just as he had predicted.

"What's this?" A girl picked up the note.

"Dreq, could you mind reading this?"

"Let me see."

"Thank you. Tell me what it says later."

"Okay.... As if I'd tell you."

Dreq exclaimed with delight immediately after reading the note. "Wow! Father needs our help. This is an excellent opportunity to make him proud of me. Of course, I'll make him proud. You can count on me, father."

"Listen, everyone. Father is in desperate need of our help. He was forced to train us for the war by evil people. He's against us going to war. He wishes for our safety and happiness. The government, however, was informed about the plan. Our father is in danger. So now we must save our father. Let's go, everyone. Let's make him proud."

"Everyone! Let us wipe out everything in our path and concentrate on saving our father."
"Yeah! Let's begin." The children responded aggressively.

Dreq announced to get erratic, which was heard by Dave from a distance. Regretfully, he never got a chance to see Dreq's face, so he never knew what the boy looked like. Then the kids went on a rampage.

** *At the scene of Albert's injury* **

"These children have only one goal in life: to die for the country." I don't care if they die battling or as the outcome of experiment. The only thing that matters to me is my pride. I don't care how many sacrifices I have to make to keep my pride. I'll do everything I can to protect myself. I'm going to destroy everything, including you, Dave. So you'd better not get in my way." An injured Albert confronted Dave right after he knocked Dreq out.

"Why, Albert?.... Why are you like this?" Dave sobbed.

"Shut up. You tell me why you manipulated Dreq. Why did you made him go against me? Why?...."

"Why can't you get it? Everything you did was wrong. It was immoral. It was absolutely immoral. You know what? That was totally evil. How can you be so callous? Huh? How could you do that to those children? What exactly did they do to-"

"**FUCK YOU!....**" Albert spat on Dave's face.

"Goodbye, Albert." Dave punched Albert with a solid punch across his chin and burned the room right in front of him.

“**CURSE YOU!....**" Albert screamed in agony as Dave left the scene. He was completely devastated by his brother's betrayal. That moment did severe damage to him before the flames completely ravaged everything that was present.

—

"Great! This is what I was hoping to hear from you." Dreq applauded Dave's candor.

"It's betrayal, isn't it?" Dave inquired.

"Huh?...." Dreq smoked a cigarette once more.

"You're going to kill me because I killed Albert. Isn't that right?"

"Shhhh.... **YOU DID NOT KILL ALBERT!**"

"What?...." Dave was taken aback when he heard that.

"Yes. You didn't....."

"I don't get it...."

"Let me explain. Of course, it was you who set fire to the entire establishment. You were so intent on destroying him that you didn't even look around the hall. What if people were still there? What if someone was privy to all of your activities? Isn't that a possibility?...."

"Ahh...." Dave stumbled.

“Now, it’s your turn to seek the truth.”

“....”

“You’ll know the reason behind your death soon.”

“....”

“Let me tell you what happened after you left the room.”

Dave's eyes, which were filled with utter confusion, represented extreme uncertainty and dread. In response, Dreq had a menacing smile on his face as he continued to stare into Dave's eyes.

"FUCK! This is such a disgraceful moment for me. How could I die in such a pitiful manner? FUCK! Fuck you, Dave. Fuck you. Fuck you too, Dreq. Fuck yo-" Albert turned to curse Dreq, and as he did, he spotted him standing directly behind him.

"...." Dreq silently stood there, gazing into his father's eyes. Abruptly, he glanced around him, into the room that was presently on fire. But then his attention turned to his father's broken leg and his pitiful, helpless predicament.

"DREQ!.... Don't just stare at me like that. Help me. Help your father."

"...." He kept his eyes fixed on his father.

"I'm sorry for all the beating I gave you. I apologize for being so mean to you. Please forgive your father..."

"...."

"You're my devoted son, aren't you? You're my good son, Dreq. I love you, so please help-"

"Shhhh...." Dave sat down next to Albert while shutting him with his finger before his mouth, and he took the pocket knife Albert had with him.

"What are you doing?...."

"Isn't this your favorite weapon? Isn't this your ancestral representation?"

"Of course it is. Do you want that? I'll give you this. Help me. Dreq, you're my good son. I love you so-" Dreq stabbed him in the throat with the knife.

"Why?.... Dreq?...." Albert had trouble speaking after the knife pierced his throat.

"**BECAUSE I AM YOUR EVIL SON.**" Subsequently, Dreq pushed the knife deeper, killing Albert in the process.

“YOU WANTED ME TO BECOME EVIL, ISN’T IT? IF THAT’S WHAT YOU WANT, I WILL BECOME YOUR EVIL SON. I WILL MAKE YOU PROUD, FATHER. I’LL MAKE YOU SO PROUD OF ME-” With these words, Dreq exited the scene directly through the burning door, which severely burned all of his upper body. As soon as he emerged, he felt himself losing consciousness on the ground. And it was there that Sera picked him up, along with two other children, on their way out of the ward.

—

"BINGO!" Dreq ridiculed a helpless Dave.

"...." "

That's all."

"...."

“So, did you get it? The reason for your demise...."

"Yes..."

“What is it? Tell me.” Dreq pestered Dave.

"You've earned my gratitude. You truly accomplished what you wanted. You truly are the devil and the most evil man I have ever come across in my life. You really are evil...." Dave cracked up and felicitated Dreq.

"Shhhh.... Huh. It's about time, isn't it?" Dreq tossed the cigarette out of his mouth and forced Dave to stand up by grabbing his collar.

"**Your final words?**" Dreq demanded.

"**PROTECT MAZE.**" Dave pleaded with him right away.

"**Hmm.... Okay. Let me accompany you to your deathbed. A wonderful reunion for you.**”

** *A few minutes later* **

"Jason? What are you doing here by yourself?" Maze noticed Jason exiting the restroom with wet hands.

"Is the performance over?" Dreq asked Maze.

"Obviously. I had been looking for you all along. Where did you disappear without telling me? Huh?" Maze leaned on his shoulders and sobbed softly.

"Sorry. Don't cry so easily. I'll never abandon you."

"Mhmm.... Okay.... And did you see Doc? He's nowhere to be found."

"He left...."

"Left? When and where?"

"**Somewhere far away. Somewhere so far away that it will take him an eternity to return**."

"Answer me seriously. Where did he go?"

"He left but didn't tell me when and where."

"Is that so?"

"Never mind, my hands are cold. Would you mind moving somewhere warmer?"

"It's bitterly cold outside. Where do you expect to find warmth?"

"Come along with me. Have a look outside." Dreq pointed to a recently built burning wood.

"A bonfire? Where'd this come from? Look at those massive woods."

"I recently finished building these. I guess like half an hour ago. My hands were filthy because of the woods, so I went to wash them."

Dreq blithely addressed everything to Maze, but only he was aware of the darkness lurking in those burning woods. An act so heinous that even the devil would bow in grace.

"You really did all that? Wow!"

“Thank you. Now then, shall we?”

“Let's go. We could spend the entire night here.

“Yes, we can do that too.”

“Don’t you think the same? You and me, between the mist. It would be so beautiful.”

“Yes. Now, let’s go.”

“Yes, yes. It would have been more fun if Doc had been here."

“**He’s always present. In the midst of us....**”

The conclusion depicted the most unexpected and darkest outcome for our protagonist. That particular evening endured until the moon was obscured by gloomy clouds, illustrating how uncertain and twisted the real world could become. It wasn't an idyllic conclusion.

Furthermore, that particular evening had a significant influence on two major aspects of our narrowly focused character, Maze. Firstly, Maze won't ever discover that the person she thought she was aware of is no longer Jason but rather a veiled and odious individual who will replace the past and keep concealing himself for the rest of time. Ultimately, Maze won't ever discover that the embers of that dying fire contained the burned remains of his father figure, Dave. She'll perpetually be waiting for him, while her life will be filled with concerns and hope that he'll return someday.

THE END

THE MIRAGE IN THE MIST

SWAYAM SHAKYA

A MYSTERY/THRILLER NOVEL

THE MIRAGE IN THE MIST

THE MIRAGE IN THE MIST centers around the mental turmoil and psychotic insanity of Jason, a young man in solitude haunted by his forgotten past with the stipulated turn of having no recollection of it, who decides to embark on a search to uncover the mystery and seek the truth behind every bizarre occurrence that he keeps encountering. Along the way, he gets accompanied by a number of individuals, including an elderly doctor who is also a retired surgeon and psychiatrist and now operates a clinic in the downtown area, a young lady around Jason's age who works as the doctor's assistant, and many others.

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